Screening for Global Talent

Visa menus, worker histories and the allocation of talent

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The economic question

Visa design links worker choice and government competition

Countries compete through the opportunities they offer migrants

- Workers choose among offers with different fees, eligibility conditions and rights.
- Employers influence recruitment, sponsorship and the jobs migrants can take.
- Governments design offers while anticipating workers' choices and other countries' policies.

Our contribution: a global visa Atlas linked to domestic and international careers.

▶ Contribution and literature ▶ Examples of visa offers ▶ Nationality preferences

Data: pathways and job histories

The Atlas describes the pathways available to migrants

Compare each pathway for a given migrant profile and year

- **Pathways:** work, study, family, protection, business and investment.
- **Terms:** eligibility, fees, sponsorship, work and family rights, duration and settlement.
- **Unit of analysis:** one pathway for a given **origin × destination × occupation × education × year**.

The same migrant may face several pathways with different requirements and rights.

▶ Matching profiles ▶ Categories and characteristics ▶ Pathways over time

Job histories reveal domestic and international mobility

People can change employers, occupations and countries

People and jobs in the database	Job changes in 2010–2025
549.7 million people	**892.2 million** domestic job changes
1.766 billion jobs	**83.65 million** international job changes

One person can change jobs several times, move abroad and later return or move to a third country.

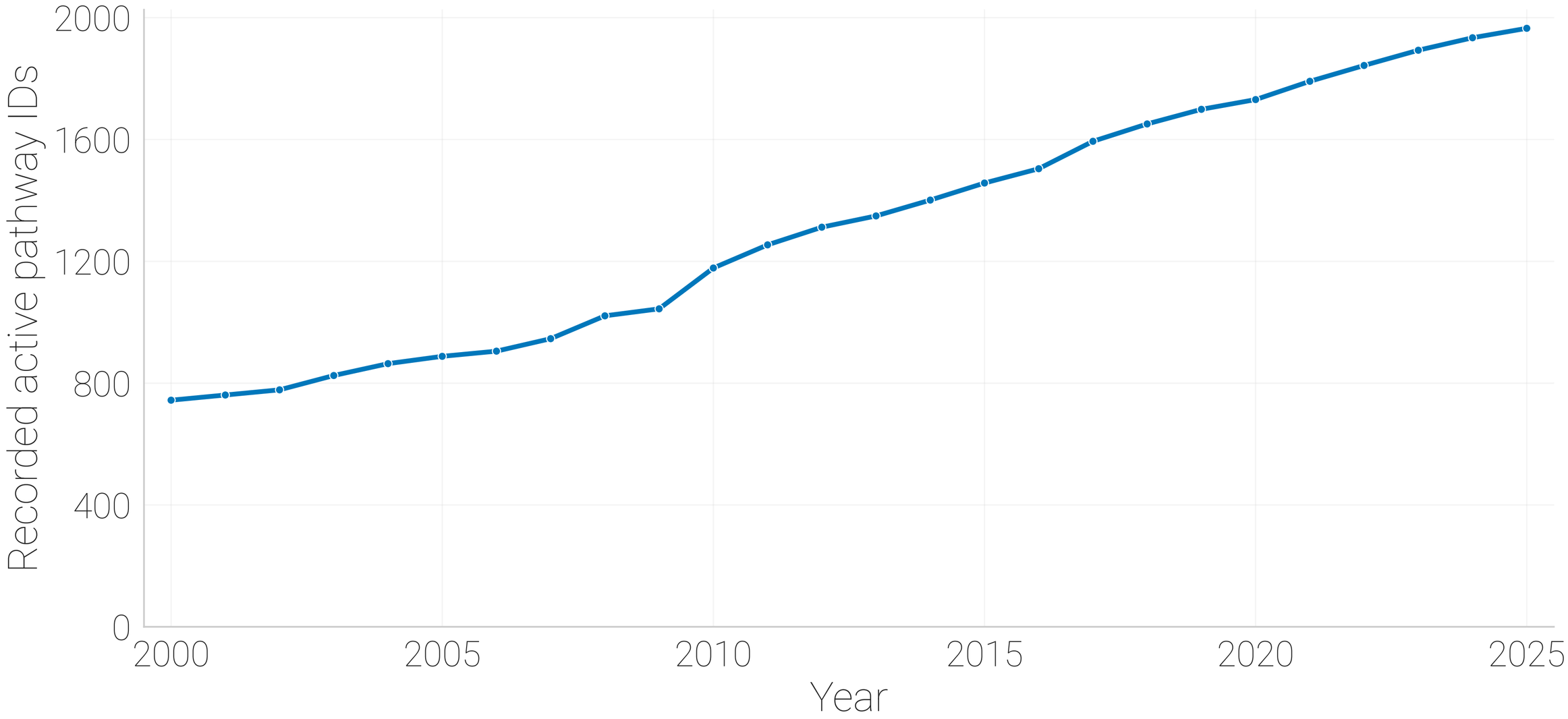
Job locations describe where a person works; residence and citizenship require separate information.

▶ Building job histories ▶ Gaps between jobs ▶ Later outcomes

More migration pathways

Recorded active pathways increase over time

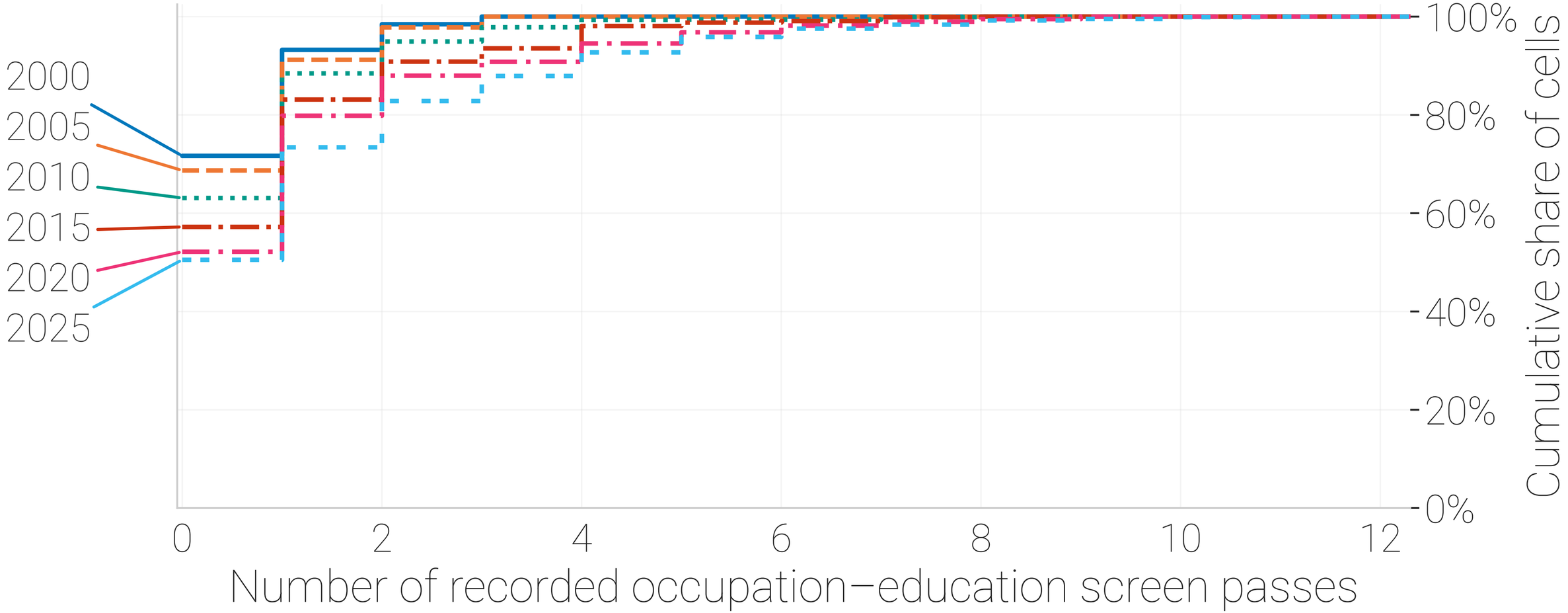
Work pathways from 2000 to 2025



▶ Country representation ▶ Appearances and endings

Recorded screen passes increase on fixed support

Compare the same destinations and migrant profiles



▶ Changing support ▶ Computer/math example ▶ Healthcare example

Different countries offer different terms

Preferential pathways involve trade-offs

Each row is a pathway for the same migrant profile

Profile: Korean nationality · Lithuania · arts occupation · undergraduate · 2024.

Pathway	Fee (€)	Processing days	Duration (months)	Permanent residence
Preferential residence permit	160	90	36	Eligible
National visa for artists	140	15	12	Ineligible

Bilateral agreements and national rules create preferences. Here, longer stays cost more and take longer to process.

▶ Nationality-specific examples ▶ Czech example

Three Czech pathways illustrate different requirements

Computer occupations, undergraduate degree, 2024

Pathway	Sponsor	Fee (CZK)	Annual salary floor (CZK)	Nationality
Digital Nomad Visa	None	2,500	780,144	AU, CA, GB, JP, KR, NZ, TW, US
Employee Card	Employer	7,500	226,800	None listed
EU Blue Card	Employer	5,000	780,138	Not reported

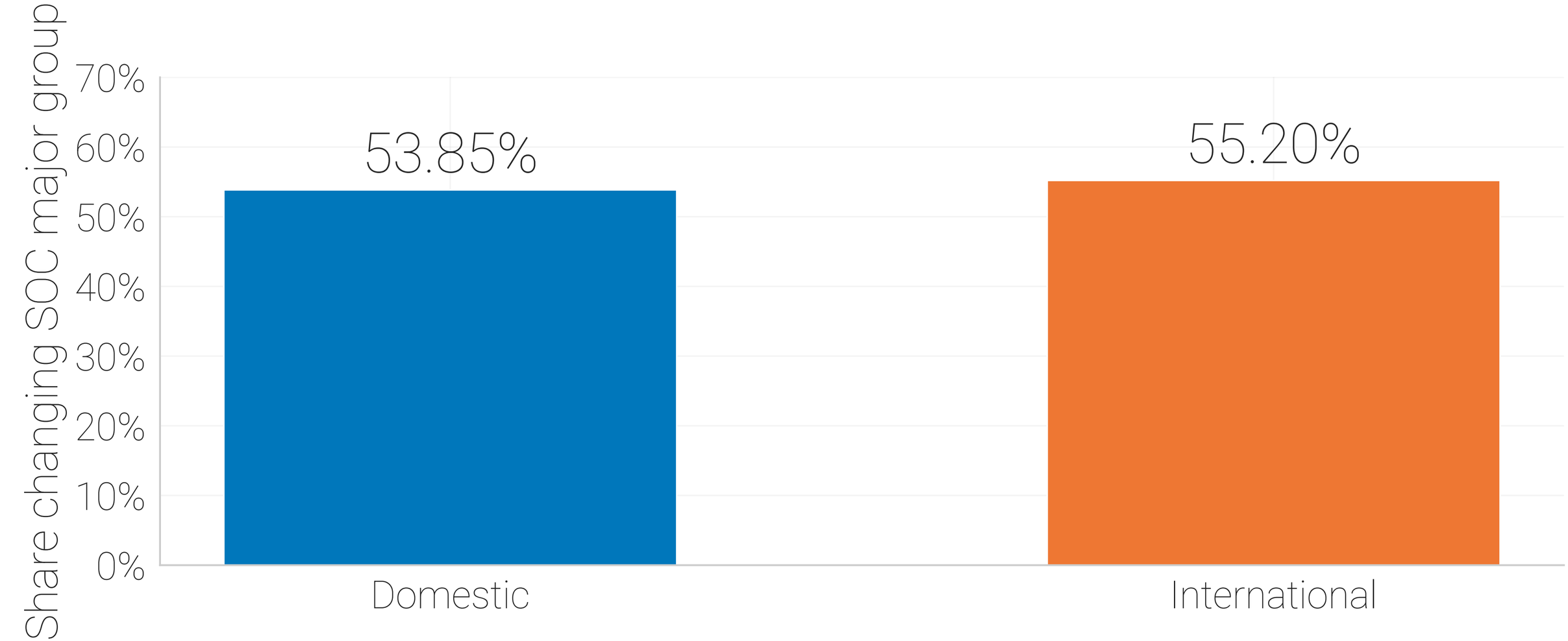
Nationality, sponsorship and salary requirements differ across these pathways.

▶ Lithuania example ▶ Nationality preferences

Job changes and international mobility

About half of job changes cross occupations

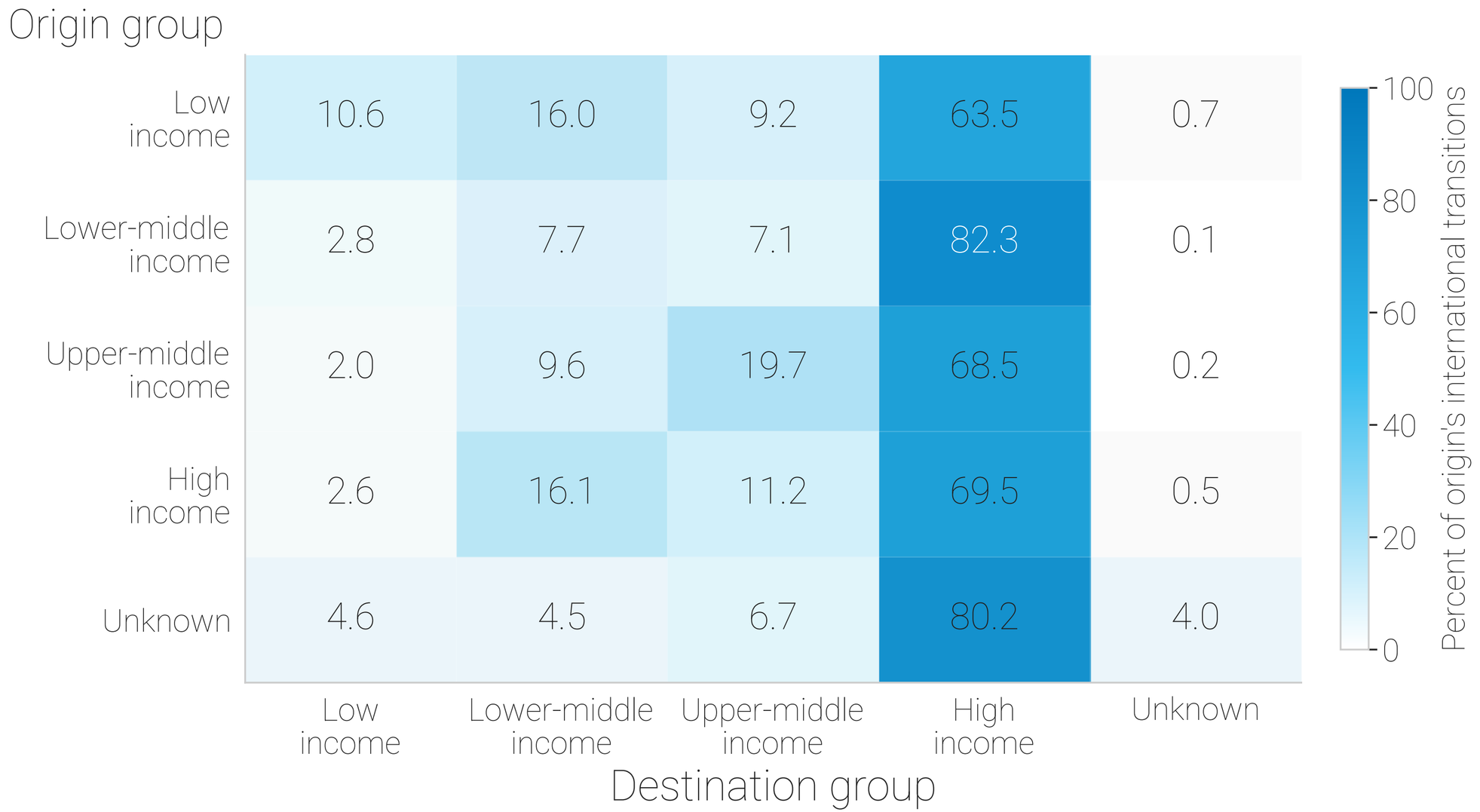
The pattern holds for domestic and international moves



▶ Income groups ▶ Occupational families ▶ Regions

International transitions between income groups

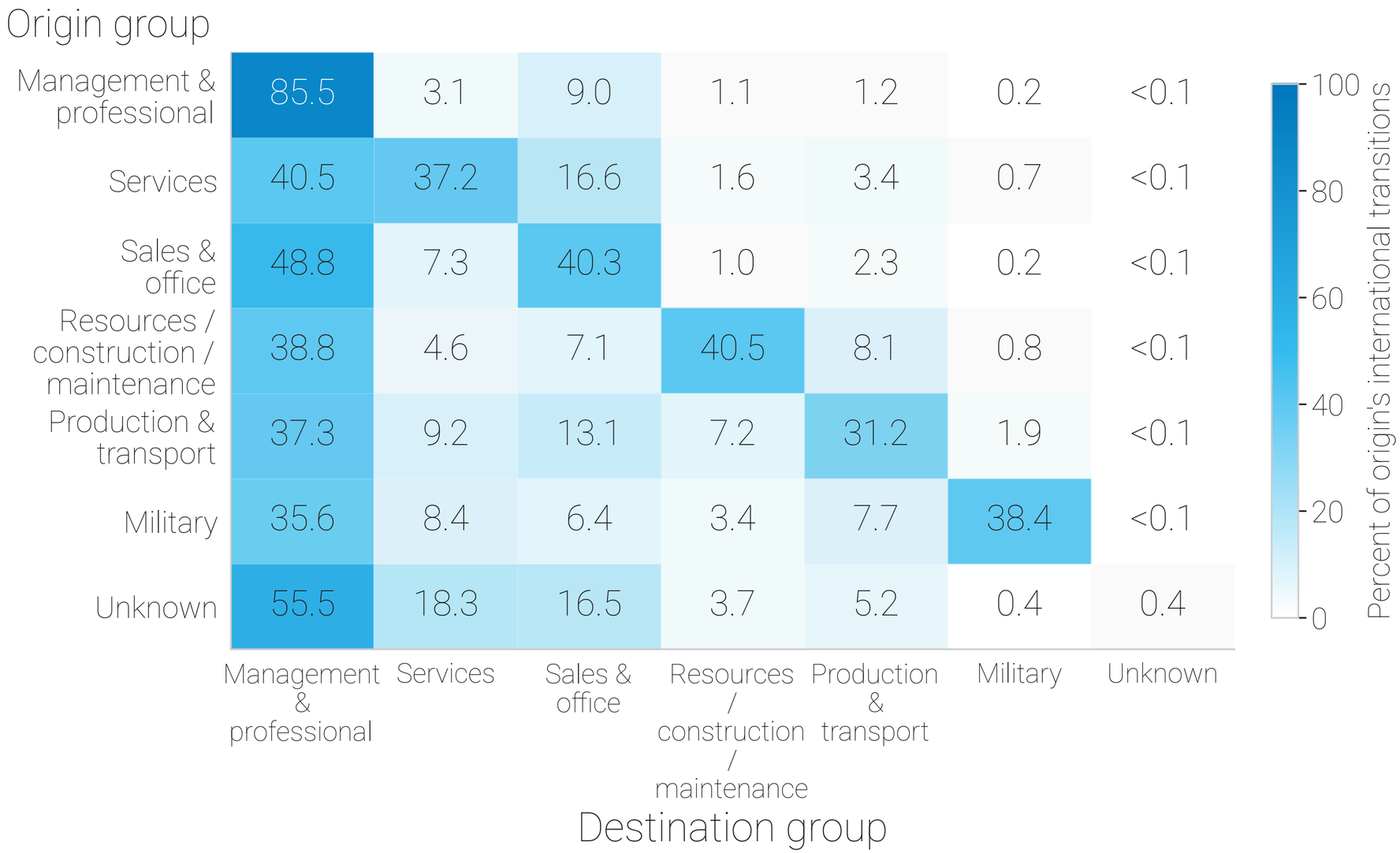
Origin and destination country-income groups, 2010–2025



▶ Counts ▶ Return: regional transitions ▶ Return: job switching

International transitions between occupational families

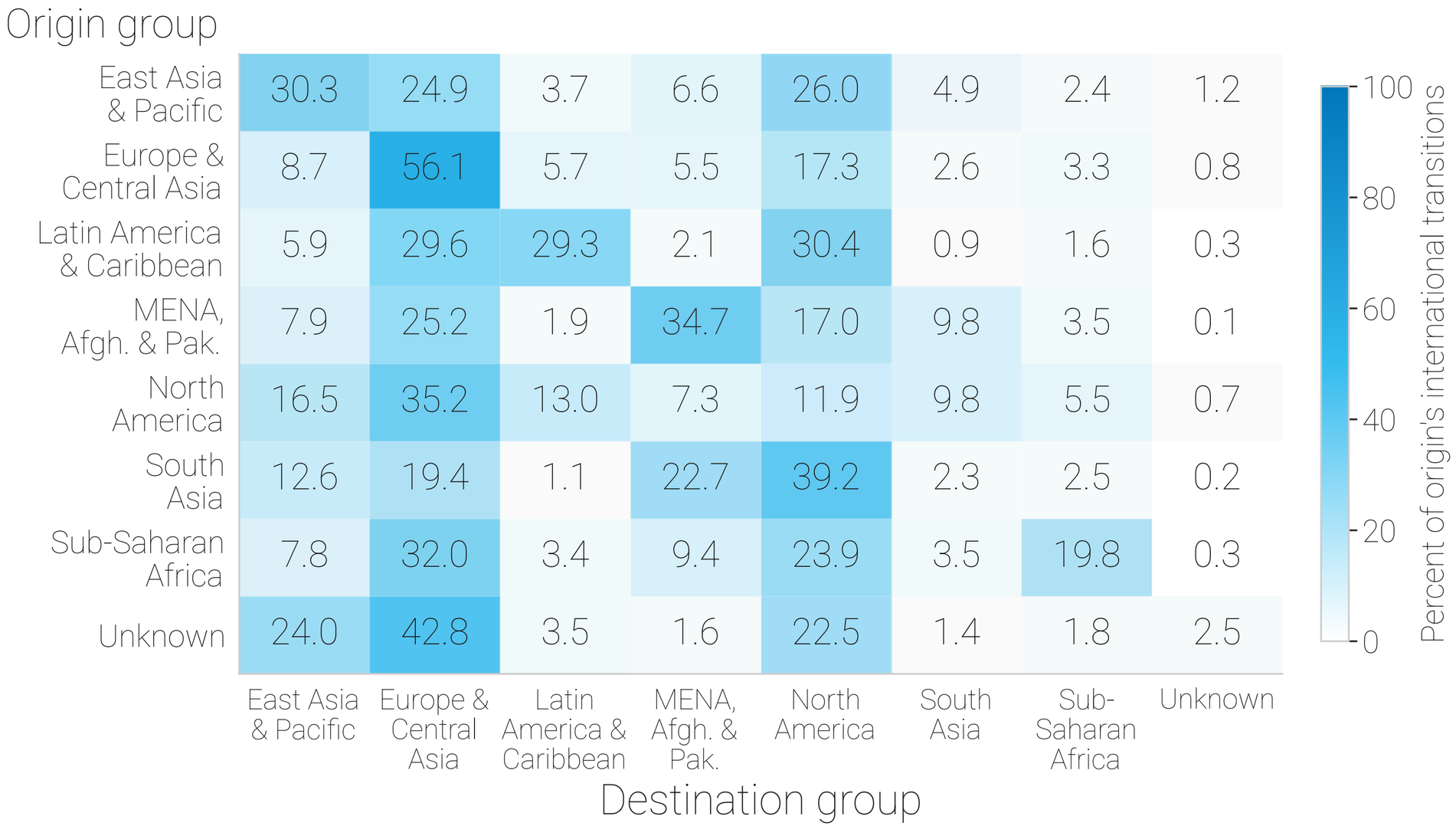
Occupations before and after an international job change



▶ Family counts ▶ All 23 SOC groups ▶ Domestic comparison ▶ Skill/task interpretation

International transitions between regions

Moves between different countries, within or across regions



▶ Region counts ▶ Income-group transitions ▶ Income counts ▶ Return: job switching

Demand, costs and visa design

Workers choose among accessible visa pathways

Fixed geography and government-chosen offers

$$u_{ijt} = \alpha \log \widetilde{w}_{ijt} + \underbrace{\beta' z_{od}}_{\text{fixed geography}} + \underbrace{\gamma' q_{jt}}_{\text{chosen visa terms}} + \xi_{jt} + \varepsilon_{ijt}, \qquad j = (d, v).$$

$$p_{ijt}(C_{it}) = \frac{\mathbf{1}\{j \in C_{it}(r_t)\} \exp(V_{ijt})}{\sum_{k \in C_{it}(r_t)} \exp(V_{ikt})}.$$

- **Net wage** $\widetilde{w}$: earnings net of taxes and fees on a common horizon.
- z: fixed geography; q: rights; r: eligibility.
- $C_{it}(r_t)$ includes staying and the worker's accessible pathways.

Migration RUMs: (Kennan & Walker, 2011).

Estimation must separate preferences from access

Gravity links choices to flows; access creates selection

$$\mu_{odt} = N_{ot} \sum_{v} \mathbb{E}[p_{i,dv,t}(C_{it}) \mid o, t].$$

Two endogenous margins: $\widetilde{w}_{ijt}$ and q_{jt} may covary with ξ_{jt}; the accessible set C_{it} is partly unobserved.

N_{ot} is the population at risk; movers alone do not identify it.

- **Offers:** demand inversion and instruments (Berry & Haile, 2024).
- **Access:** latent or restricted choice sets (Agarwal & Somaini, 2026; Almagro & Sood, 2026).
- **Information:** revealed-preference bounds (Porcher et al., 2025).

▶ Fixed effects and samples ▶ Monetary comparability ▶ Government costs

Governments choose visa policies as the supply side

Governments anticipate worker choices and rival offers

$$M_d^* \in \arg\max_{M_d \in \mathscr{M}_d} G_d(M_d, M_{-d}^*).$$

- **Menu M_d:** eligibility, rights and fees; $\mathscr{M}_d$ contains feasible policies.
- **Payoff G_d:** resident welfare and political support; recruitment, fee receipts and real costs shape the welfare component.
- **Competition:** a country's offer changes workers' alternatives to rival destinations.

Political-economy benchmark: *Protection for Sale* (Grossman & Helpman, 1994).

▶ Government objectives ▶ Welfare ▶ Conclusion

Conclusion and next steps

Visa pathways connect policy design to workers' careers

- The number of work pathways has increased.
- Pathways combine different eligibility conditions, costs and rights.
- About half of domestic and international job changes involve occupational switching.

Next steps

- Continue demand estimation, separating preferences from access.
- Develop a supply-side model of governments' visa-policy choices.

▶ Demand estimation ▶ Government policy model ▶ References

Appendix: legal offers and data

Connecting legal offers with global career allocation

Route-level policy bundles connect policy measurement with worker histories

- **Policy measurement and competition:** legal regimes select different migrants and compete for talent (Czaika & Parsons, 2017; de Haas et al., 2018; Helbling et al., 2017; Shachar, 2006).
  - → **Our contribution:** a broad motive inventory and dated, work-oriented route bundles for comparable profiles.
- **International allocation:** migration choices reallocate talent across countries and over careers (Amanzadeh et al., 2024; Bertoli & Fernández-Huertas Moraga, 2013; Bhalothia et al., 2025; Brinatti & Guo, 2024; Prato, 2025).
  - → **Our contribution:** connect legal menus to domestic and international career transitions.
- **Legal options and labour markets:** access to migrant labour, employer restrictions and connected domestic markets shape firm and worker outcomes (Borusyak et al., 2026; Doran et al., 2022; Townsend & Allan, 2025).
  - → **Our contribution:** cross-country legal-menu measurement, with competing government offers as a proposed extension.

▶ Full literature map ▶ Demand identification ▶ Government objectives ▶ Return: question

A migrant’s profile determines the relevant visa menu

Match the person, destination and year to the pathway

Profile	Visa requirements	Job histories
Year	Rules applying in that year	Job and move dates
Occupation	Occupation-specific conditions	Type of work before and after a move
Origin	Nationality or residence conditions	Previous job country; nationality is matched separately
Education	Required qualifications	Highest reported degree

Applications also depend on sponsorship, salary and other personal circumstances.

▶ Occupational groups ▶ Country coverage ▶ Missing requirements ▶ Return: Atlas

Governments offer access, costs and rights

Admission is one part of a package that shapes a person's future options

Access to employment

- Occupation, citizenship and sponsorship can determine which routes a worker can use.
- Employer portability changes the jobs available **after admission**.
- A route opening can redirect workers from another destination rather than create a new move.

Residence and membership

- Family work rights, renewal and settlement change the value of the initial offer.
- Argentina's investment-linked **citizenship** initiative illustrates a different membership instrument—not a work visa.
- Announced terms, binding rules and operational access are distinct.

How do these offers change the allocation of workers—and the offers made by rival governments?

▶ Legal examples ▶ Nationality-specific routes ▶ Return: question

Admission, residence and citizenship are distinct

Example	Institutional distinction	Presentation scope
Argentina investment-linked citizenship	2025 decrees create category/procedure; October 2026 announcement describes financial/family terms.	Citizenship, not a work visa. Exact operational opening not established.
Citizenship-conditioned work access	A potential migrant’s nationality can determine a preferential route.	Previous job country cannot assign nationality.
Employer-tied work permission	Admission may leave the holder dependent on a sponsor.	Portability and continuation can matter without an immediate move.

The US H-1B1 comparison and Germany’s Western Balkans employment regulation provide source-backed nationality examples; they are not a verified identification of the separately mentioned recent German occupation-specific announcement.

▶ Return: motivation

A nationality preference need not dominate a general route

- H-1B1 for Chile/Singapore has nationality-specific allocations and a distinct visa-abroad procedure.
- Temporary-intent and duration/renewal terms differ from the ordinary H-1B framework.
- Germany’s Western Balkans route illustrates nationality-conditioned access with different qualification rules.

Compare the whole bundle for the same applicant and date: eligibility, sponsor, fees, intent, work rights and continuation.

▶ Return: motivation ▶ Return: route bundles ▶ Return: question ▶ Return: Czechia

The broad inventory includes more than work routes

Retained category code	Entries
Work	1,480
Study	446
Family	571
Protection	576
Business/investment	579
Visit	669
Other	1,423
Total	**5,744**

Characteristic families

- Access and selection
- Fees, funds, salary and investment
- Procedures and compliance
- Work rights and portability
- Family and dependent rights
- Duration, renewal and settlement
- Identity, status and timing

The Atlas describes **80 pathway characteristics**, including eligibility, costs and rights.

▶ Return: Atlas

Route identity and annual history require validation

- ID: country plus supplied/slugified route name—not an adjudicated legal equivalence class.
- Annual states use lifecycle bounds, recorded changes and forward-filling; they are not independent annual legal observations.
- Renaming, branching and succession can change counts without adding a simultaneous option.
- Unknown, inapplicable, uncertain and known values must remain distinct.

Historical coverage differs across countries and pathways. These figures focus on 2000–2025.

▶ Return: Atlas ▶ Return: growth

Occupational detail and analytical restrictions differ

Level or selection	Count/scope	Interpretation
Official SOC major/minor/broad/detailed	23 / 98 / 459 / 867	Reference taxonomy, not observed vendor counts
Atlas major-group scenarios	22	Military excluded; national classifications mapped into SOC
Earlier skilled-group analysis	11	Analytical restriction
Current monetary gravity	15, 17, 25, 29	Four selected major groups
Retained Revelio source	O*NET code; older `role_k1500` fallback	Fine counts, complete vendor hierarchy and edition unverified

The observed occupation source includes military and malformed values. Exact recognized-code rules differ from simply taking two initial characters.

▶ Return: bridge ▶ Return: occupations ▶ Return: skills

Different questions use different parts of the job history

Object	People	Positions/events
People with job histories	549,729,026	1,765,970,337 positions
Strict whole histories	303,499,990	1,117,773,296 positions
Job changes after removing uncertain histories	—	814,273,306 events
Job changes with known countries, 2010–2025	—	975,853,764 events

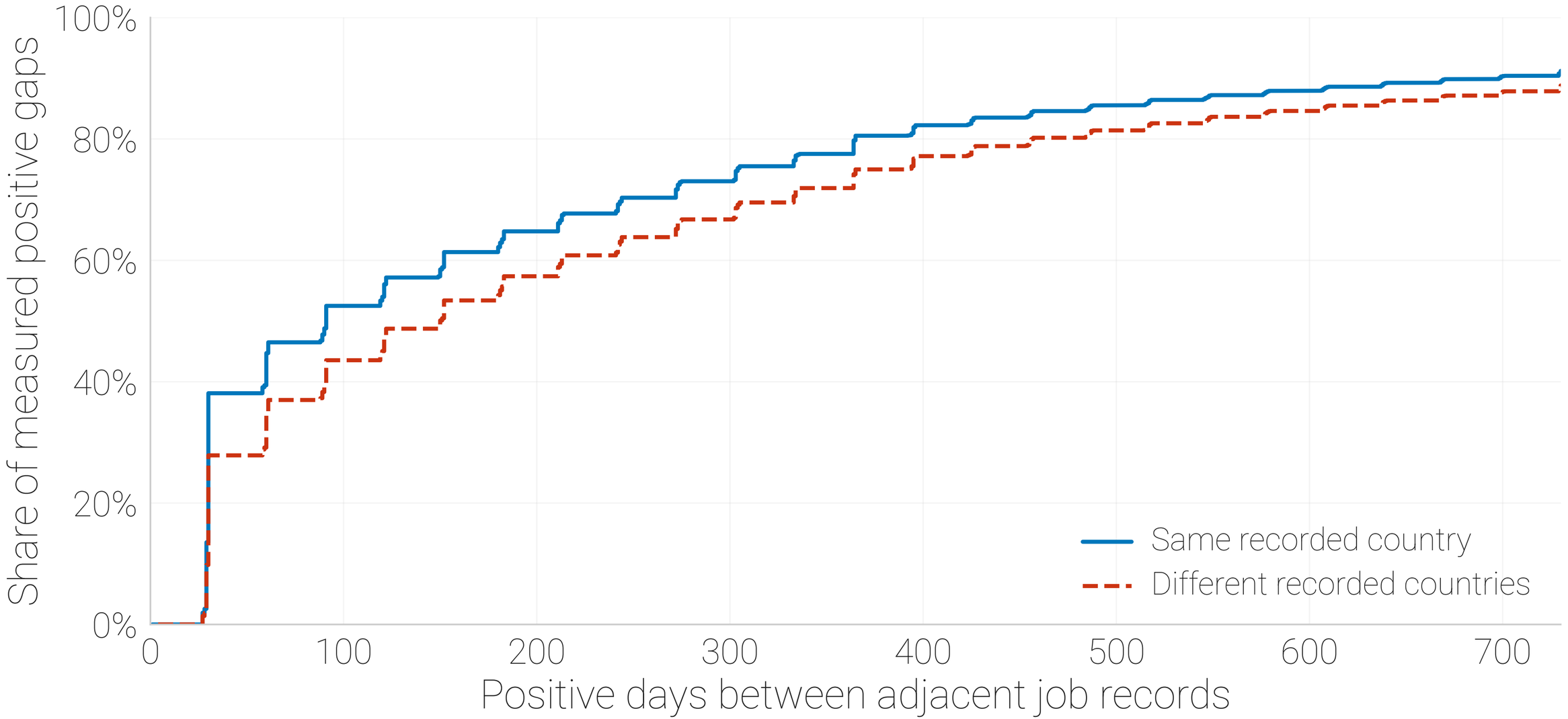
Missing starts, countries and tied starts have **overlapping** exclusion counts. The strict rule excludes a person if any history record fails; the broad geography construction removes missing-country records before ordering.

These are different populations, not successive rows in one funnel. Concurrent positions, missing ends and chronology cannot be resolved by arbitrary sorting.

▶ Return: histories

Many positive gaps are short; missing updates still matter

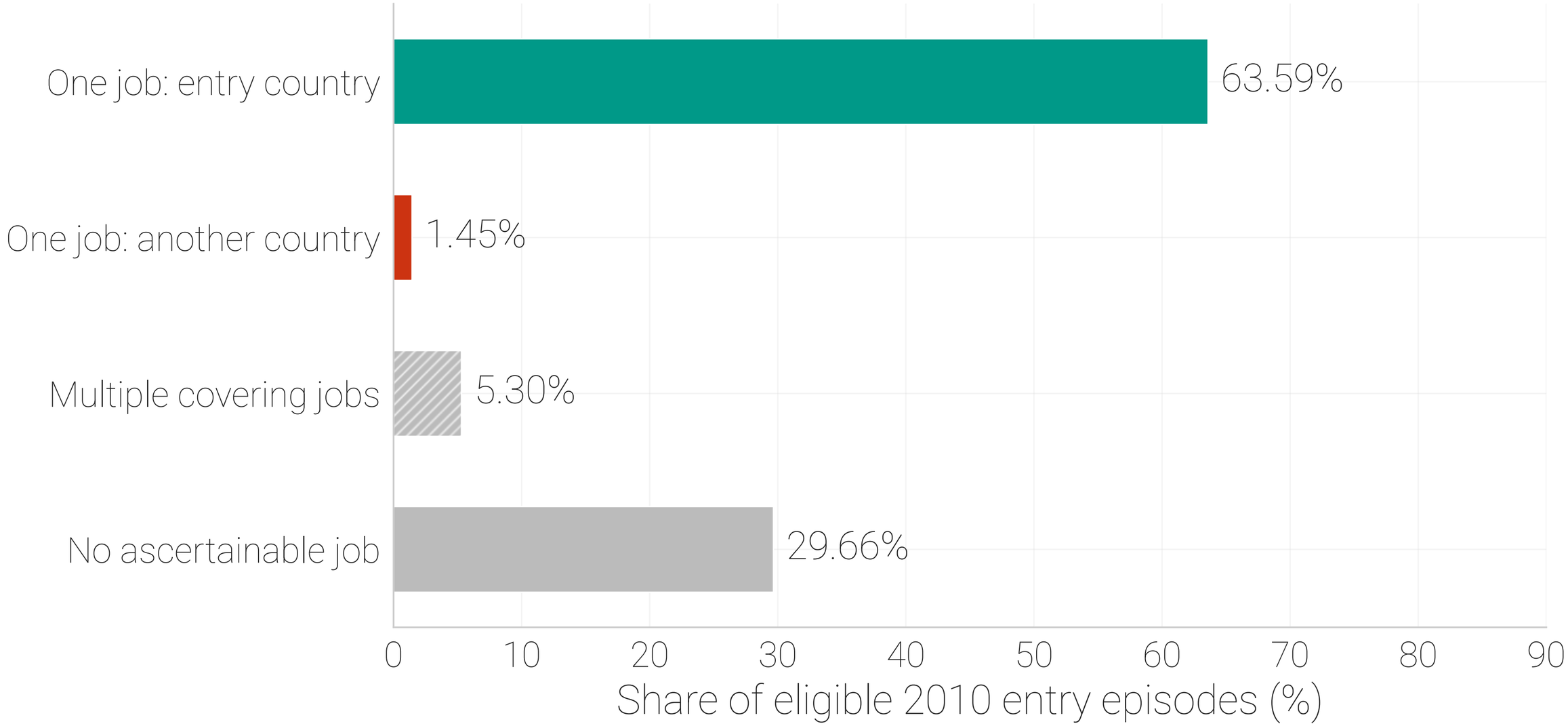
Measured positive adjacent-record gaps · not unemployment or legal-status gaps



▶ Return: histories

A fixed horizon requires a job covering the endpoint

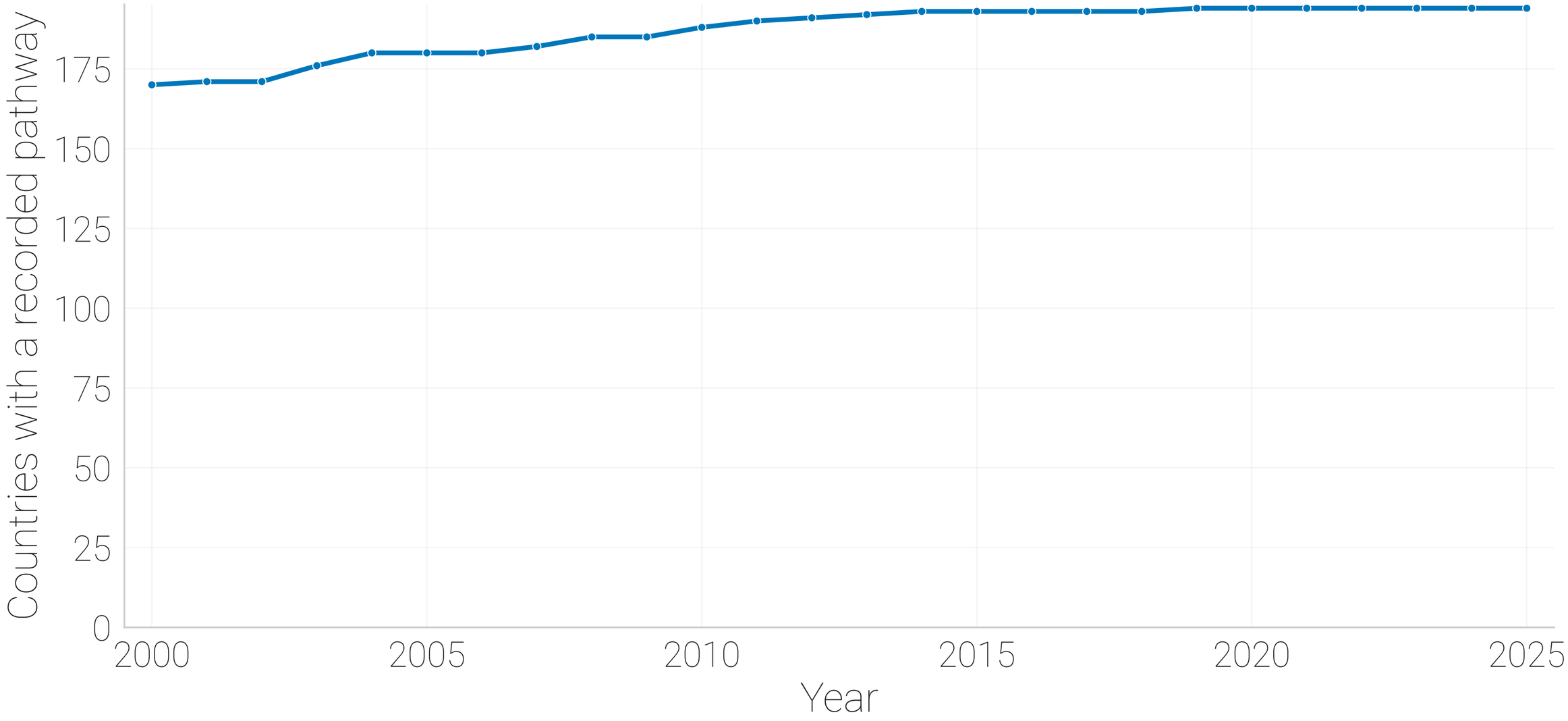
Corrected one-year endpoint comparison · unresolved follow-up is separate



▶ Return: histories

Historical representation broadens over time

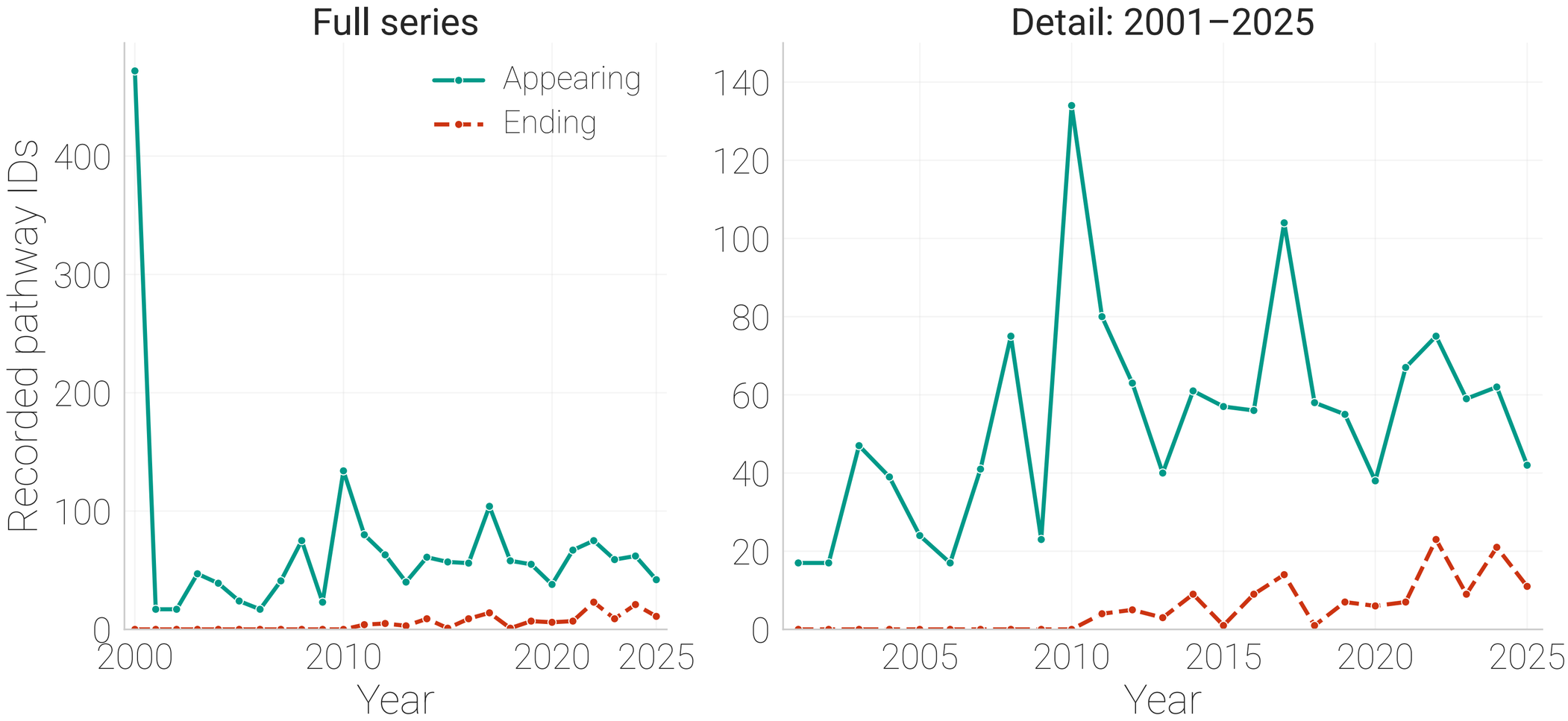
Represented destination labels · not necessarily new policy adopters



▶ Return: growth ▶ Return: bridge

Recorded appearances and endings are not legal births and deaths

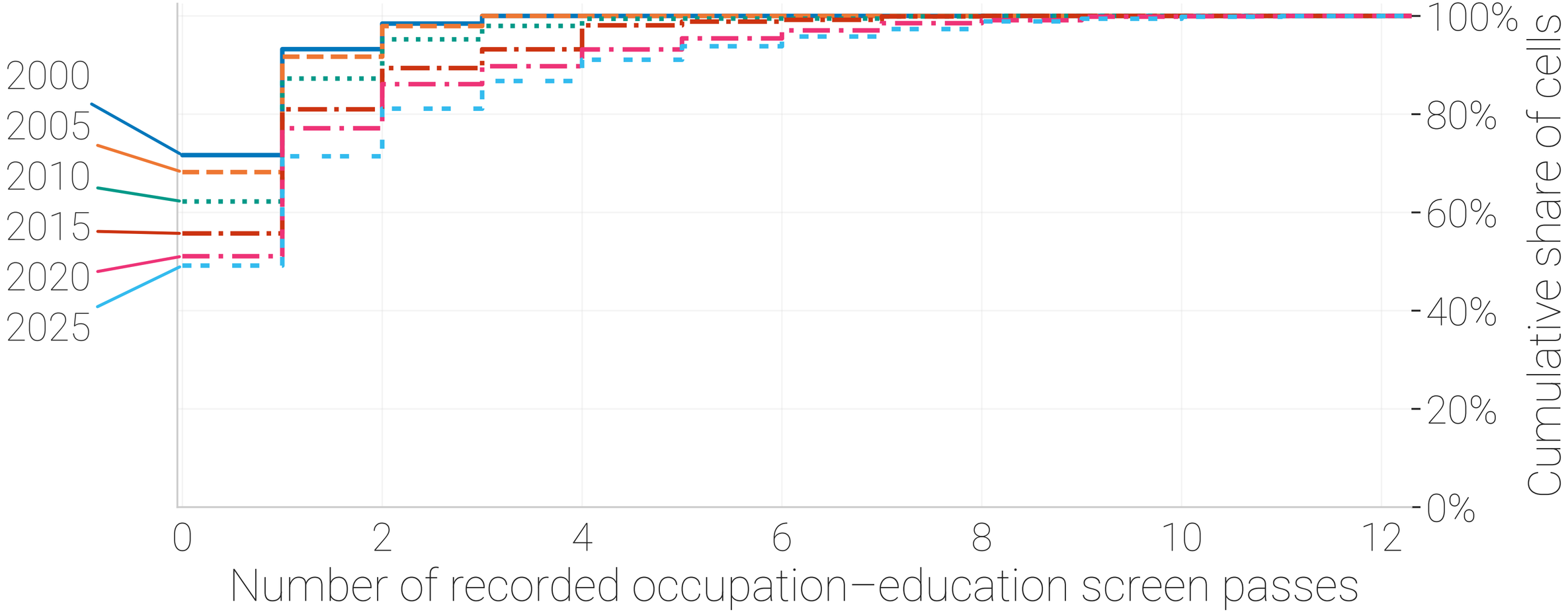
The 2000 boundary and unresolved status affect lifecycle interpretation



▶ Return: growth

Changing support gives a different pooled comparison

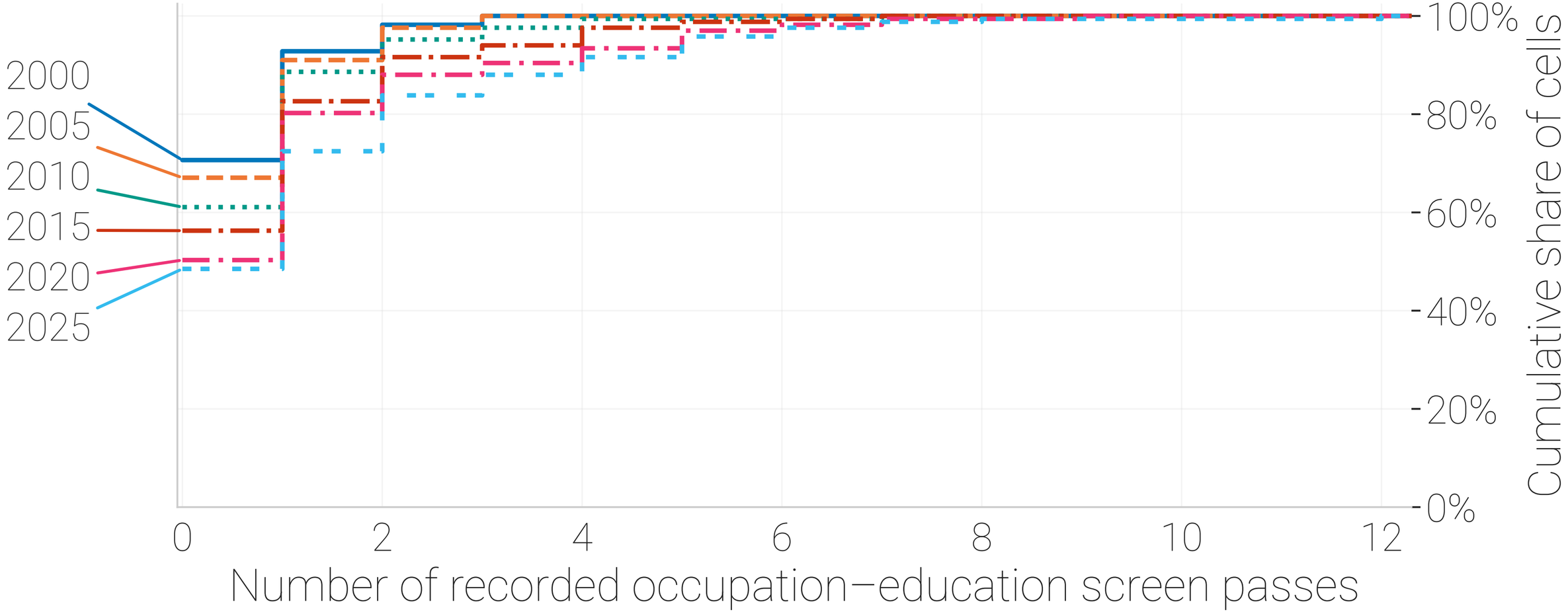
Changing destination support · occupation–education scenarios · six dates



▶ Return: fixed-support result

Computer/mathematical profile: fixed-support comparison

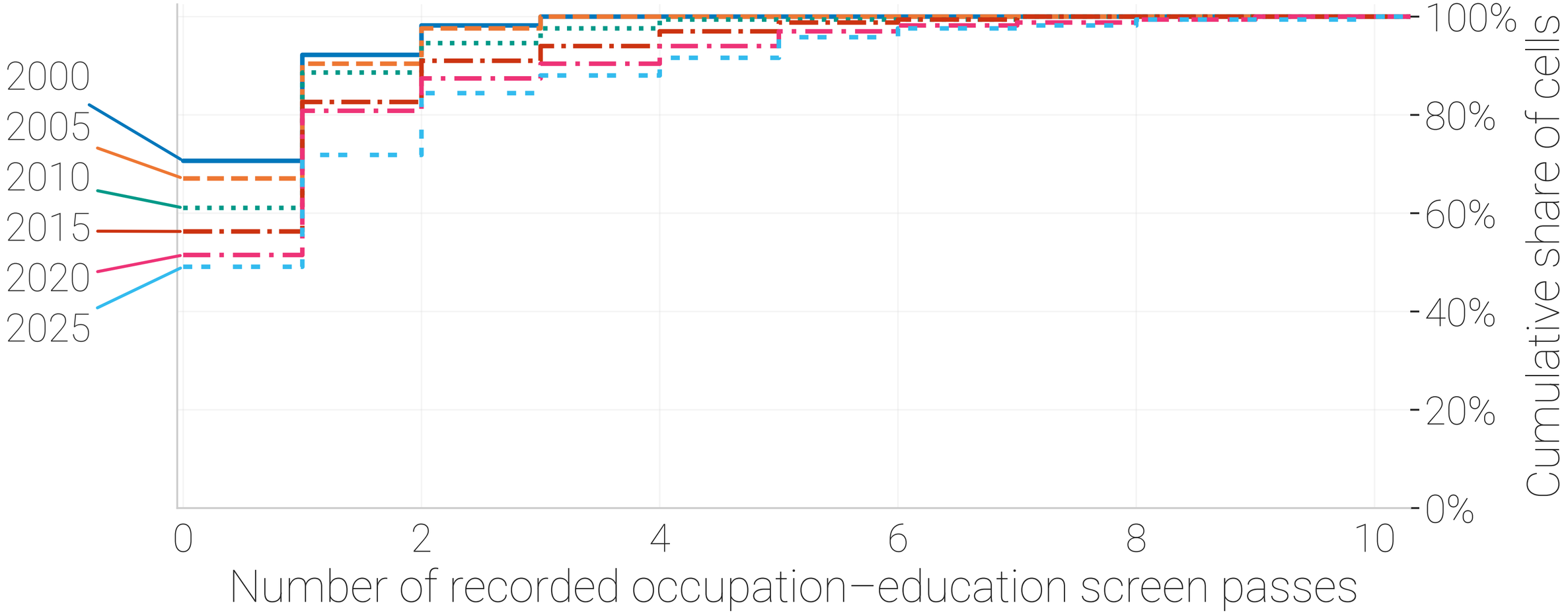
SOC 15 · undergraduate screen · six dates · no nationality or age screen



▶ Return: pooled profiles

Healthcare-practitioner profile: fixed-support comparison

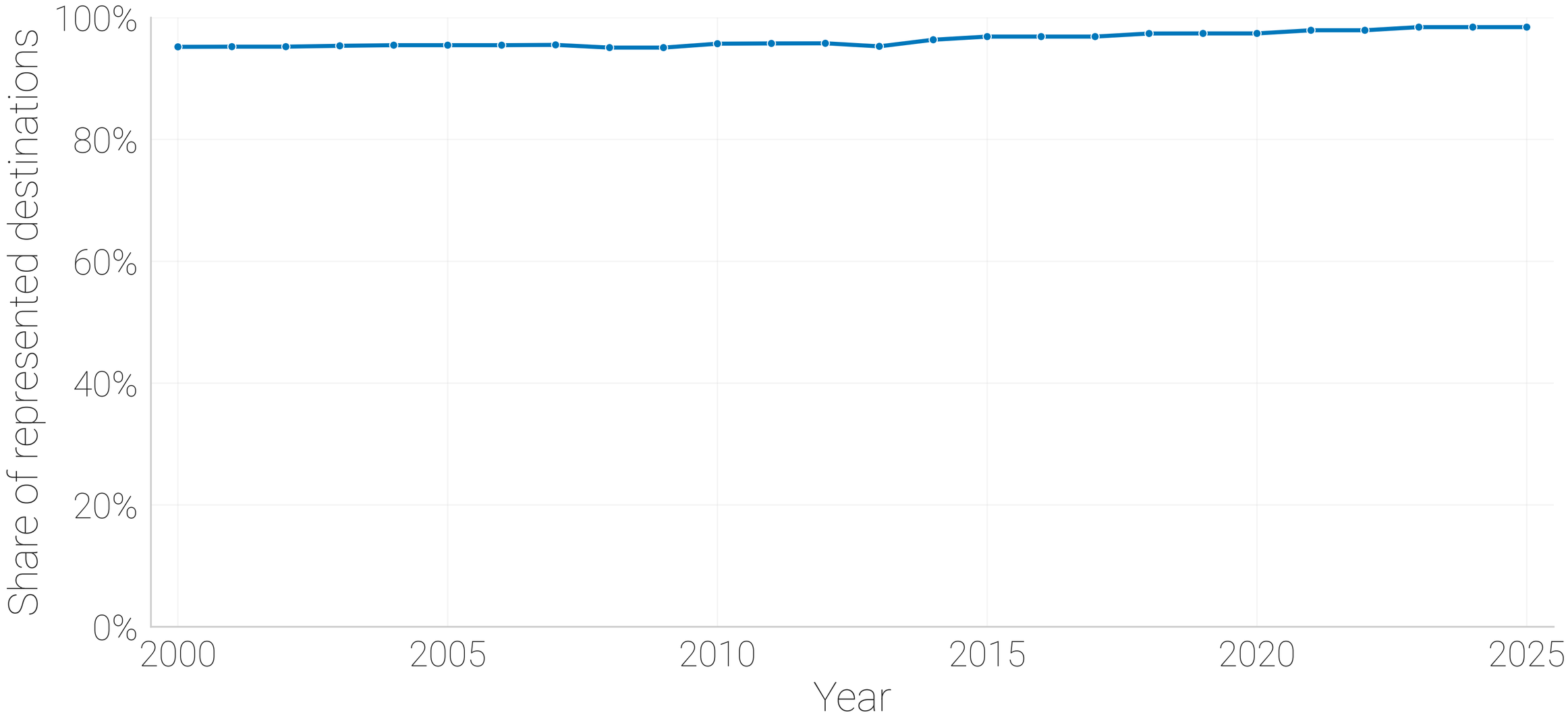
SOC 29 · undergraduate screen · six dates · no nationality or age screen



▶ Return: pooled profiles

Unresolved rules prevent a complete legal-menu interpretation

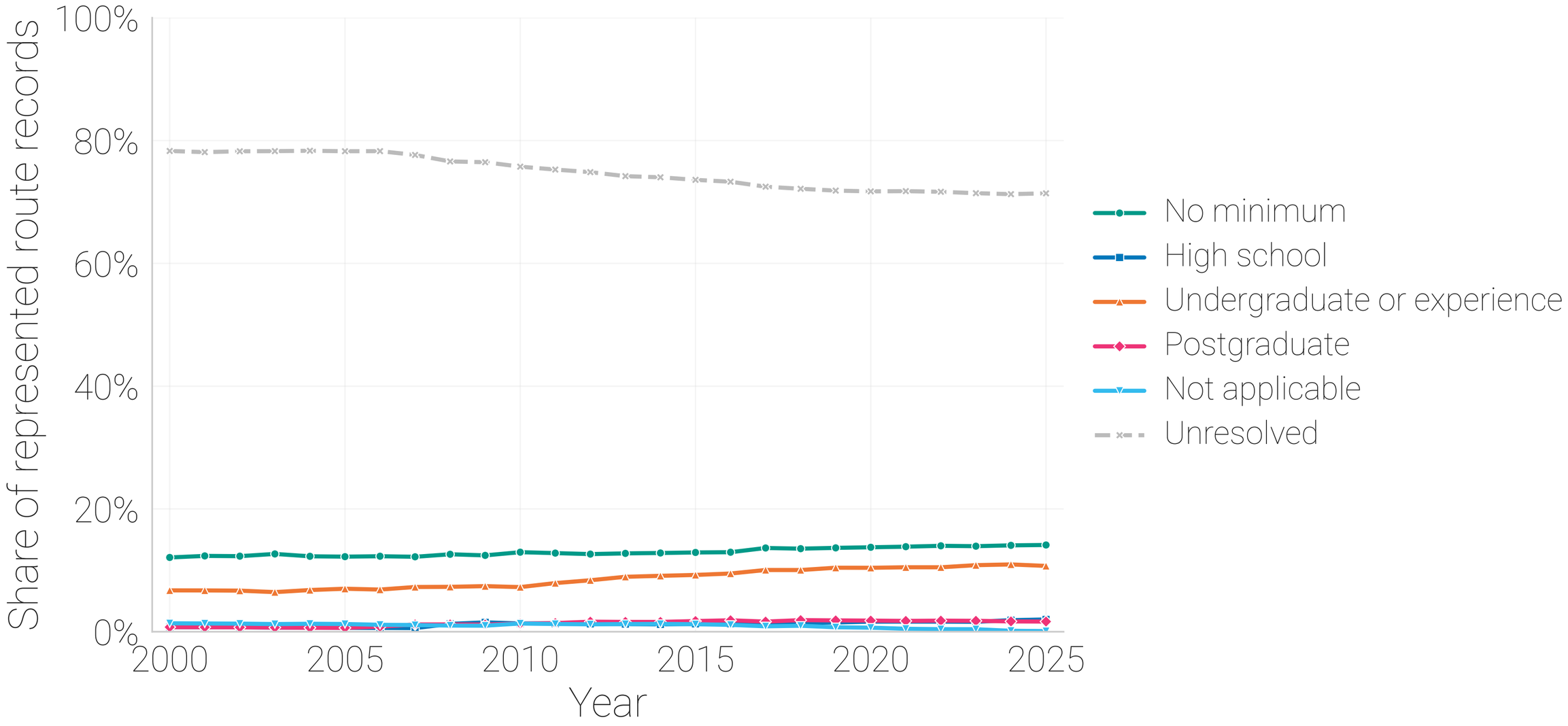
Recorded pass counts and unresolved evaluations are different objects



▶ Return: bridge ▶ Return: pooled profiles

Credential requirements are often unresolved

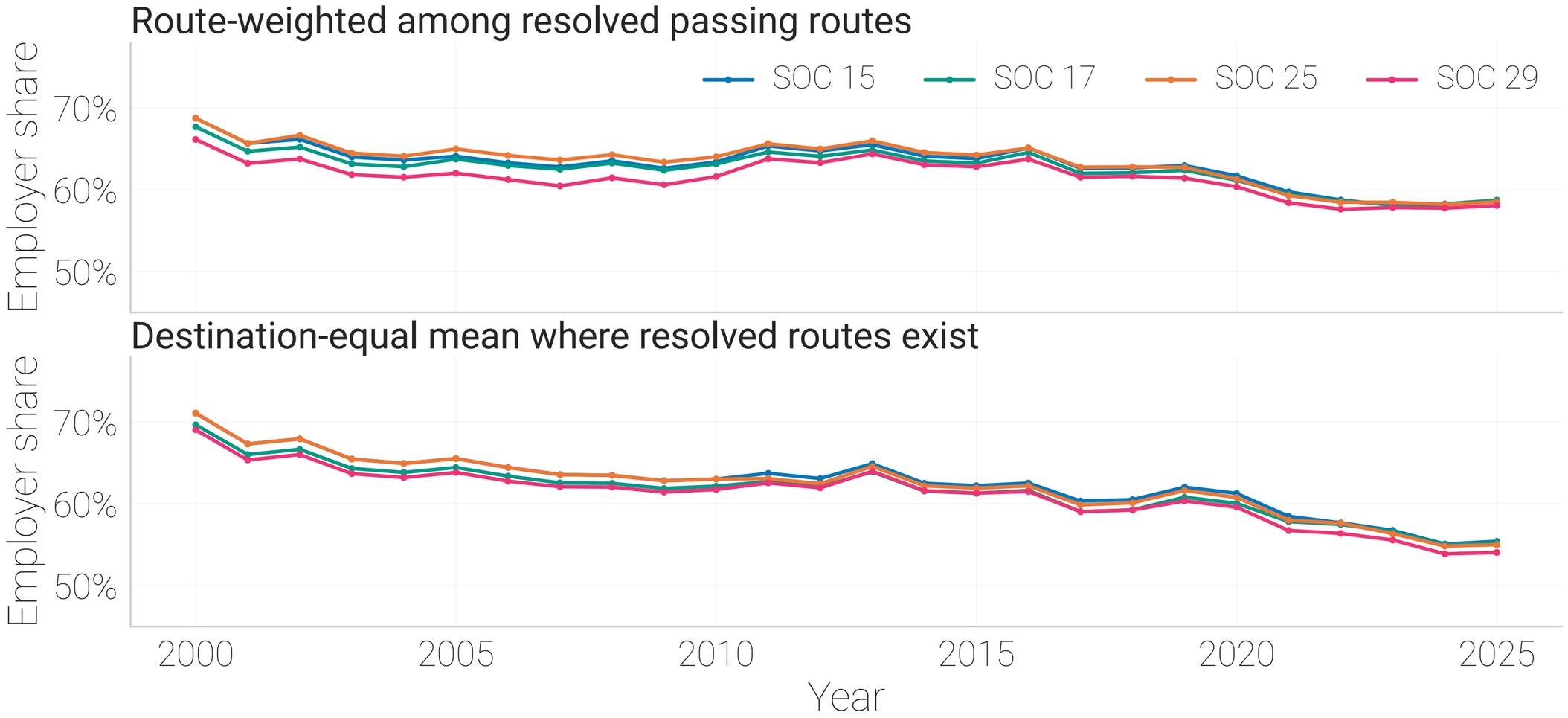
2000–2025 · represented route records · not an ordinal route-skill ranking



▶ Return: screening

Employer sponsorship remains common as its recorded share falls

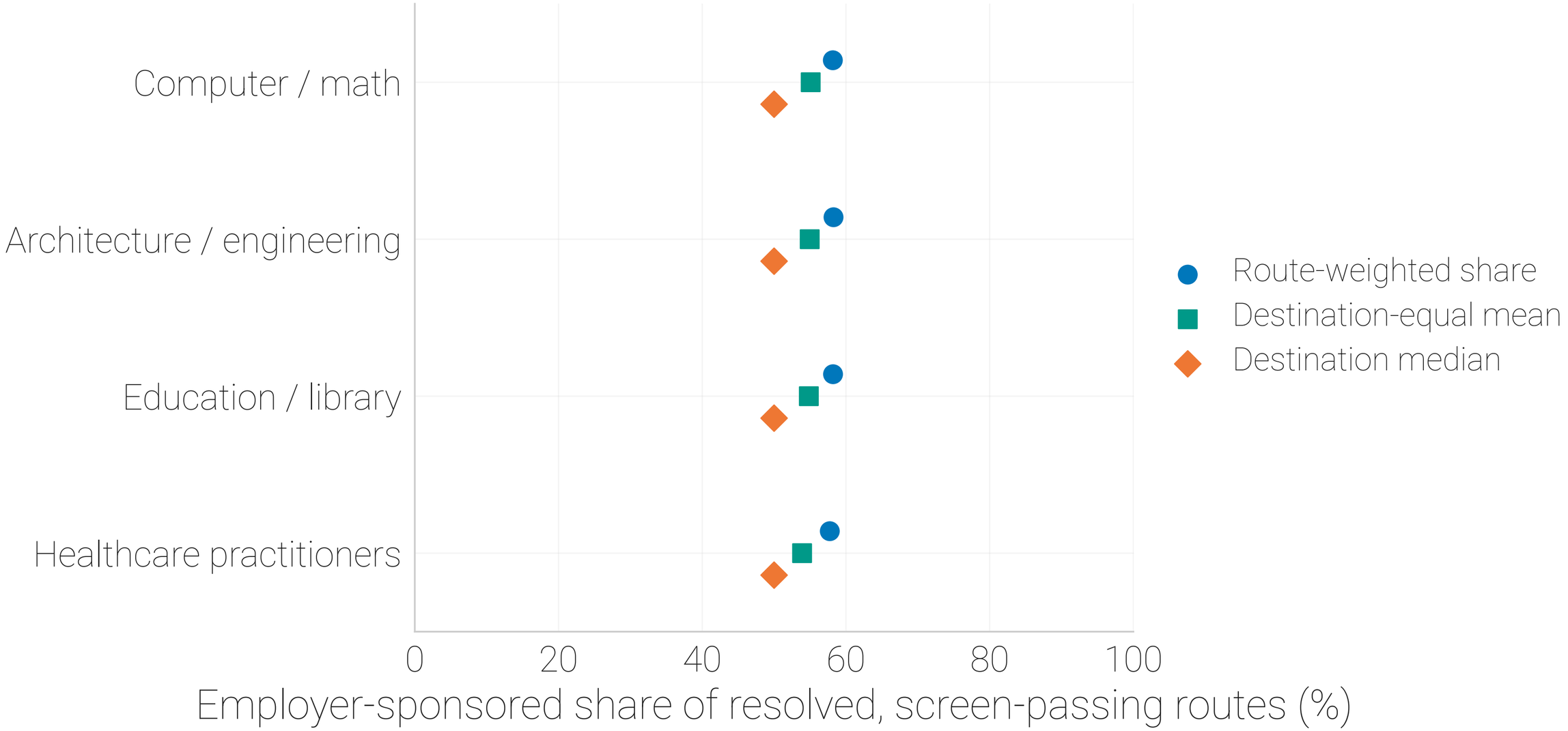
2000–2025 · four occupation profiles · undergraduate screen · resolved sponsorship



▶ Weights ▶ Education rules ▶ Family rights ▶ Fee contrasts

Sponsorship shares depend on the weighting rule

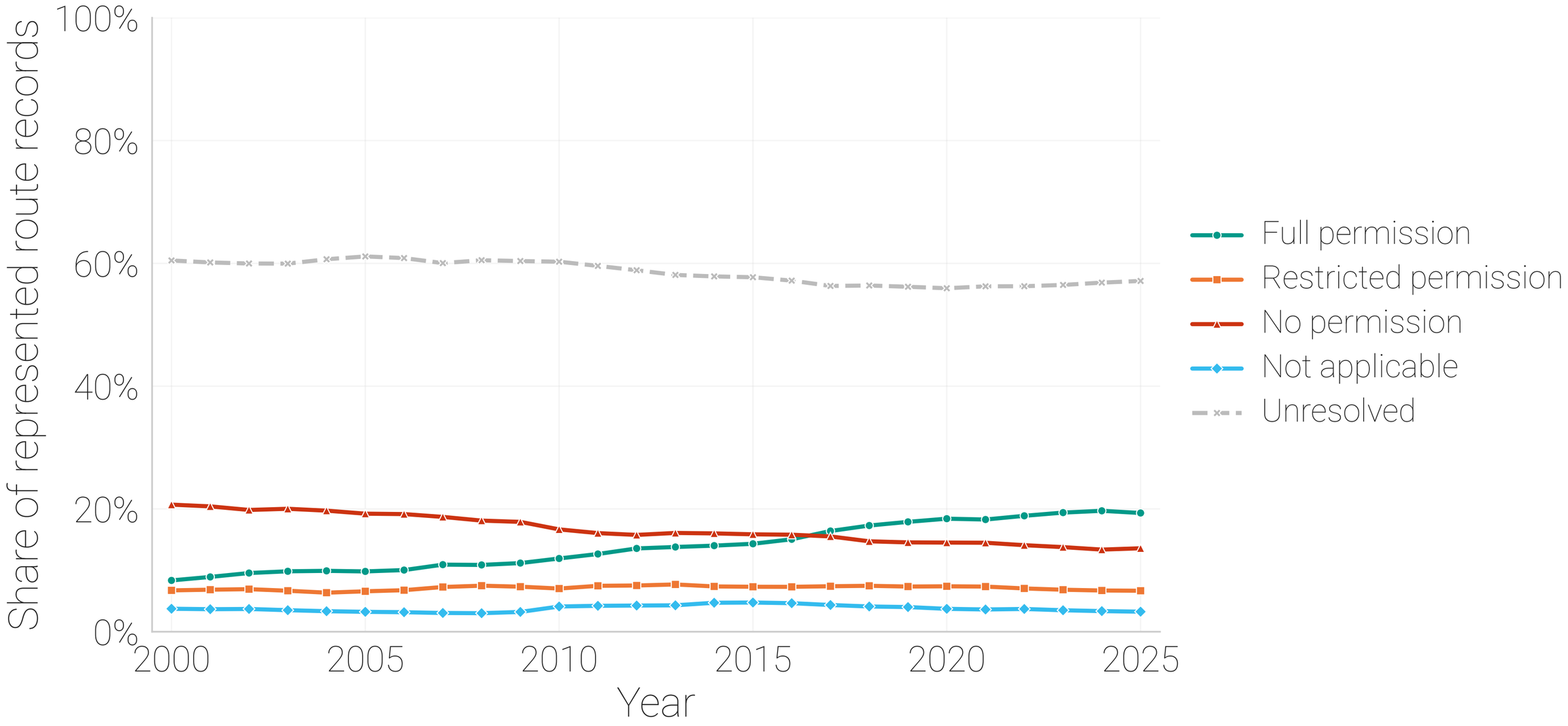
2024 · route-weighted, destination-equal and median comparisons



▶ Return: screening

Spouse work rights are one part of the route bundle

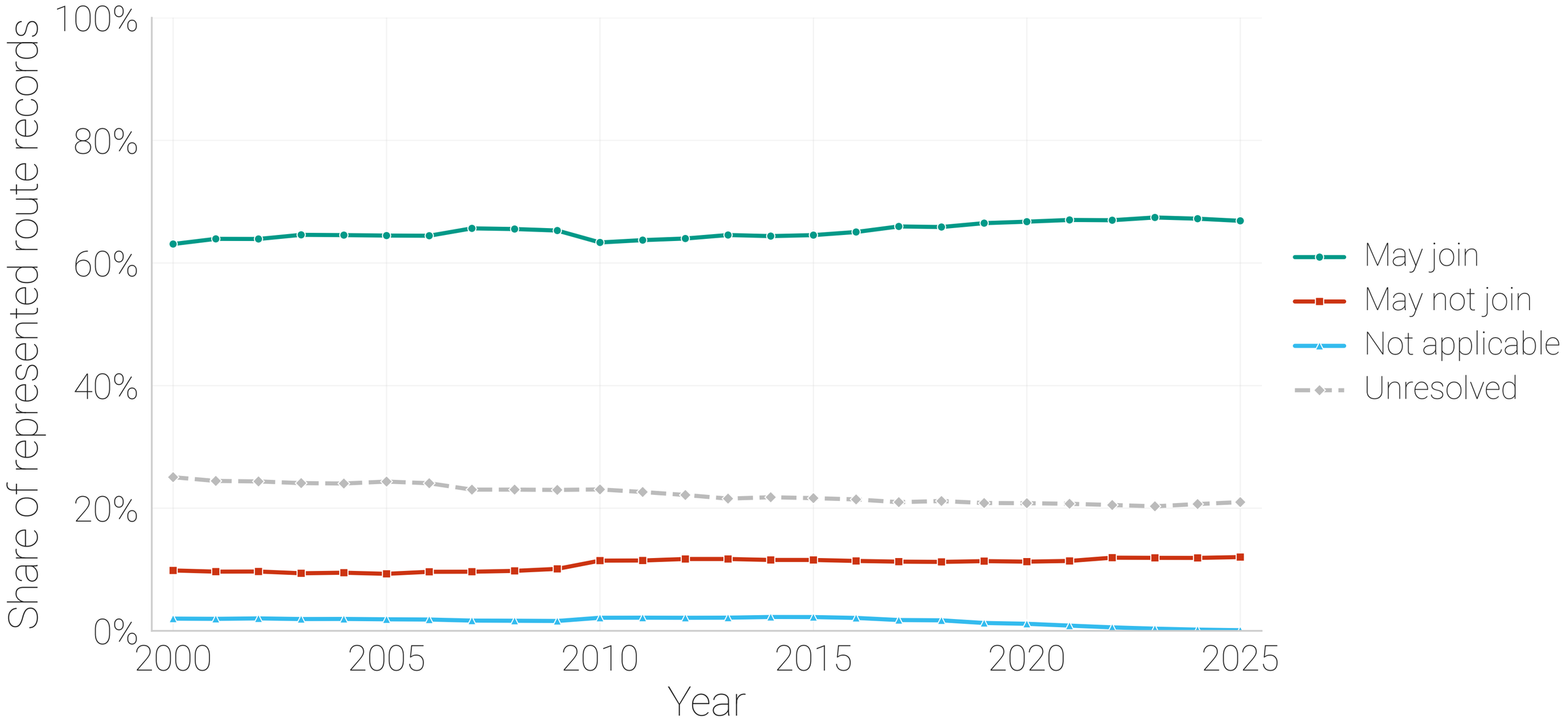
Represented route records · not an active-only or applicant-weighted denominator



▶ Dependent access ▶ Return: screening

Dependent access and dependent work rights are distinct

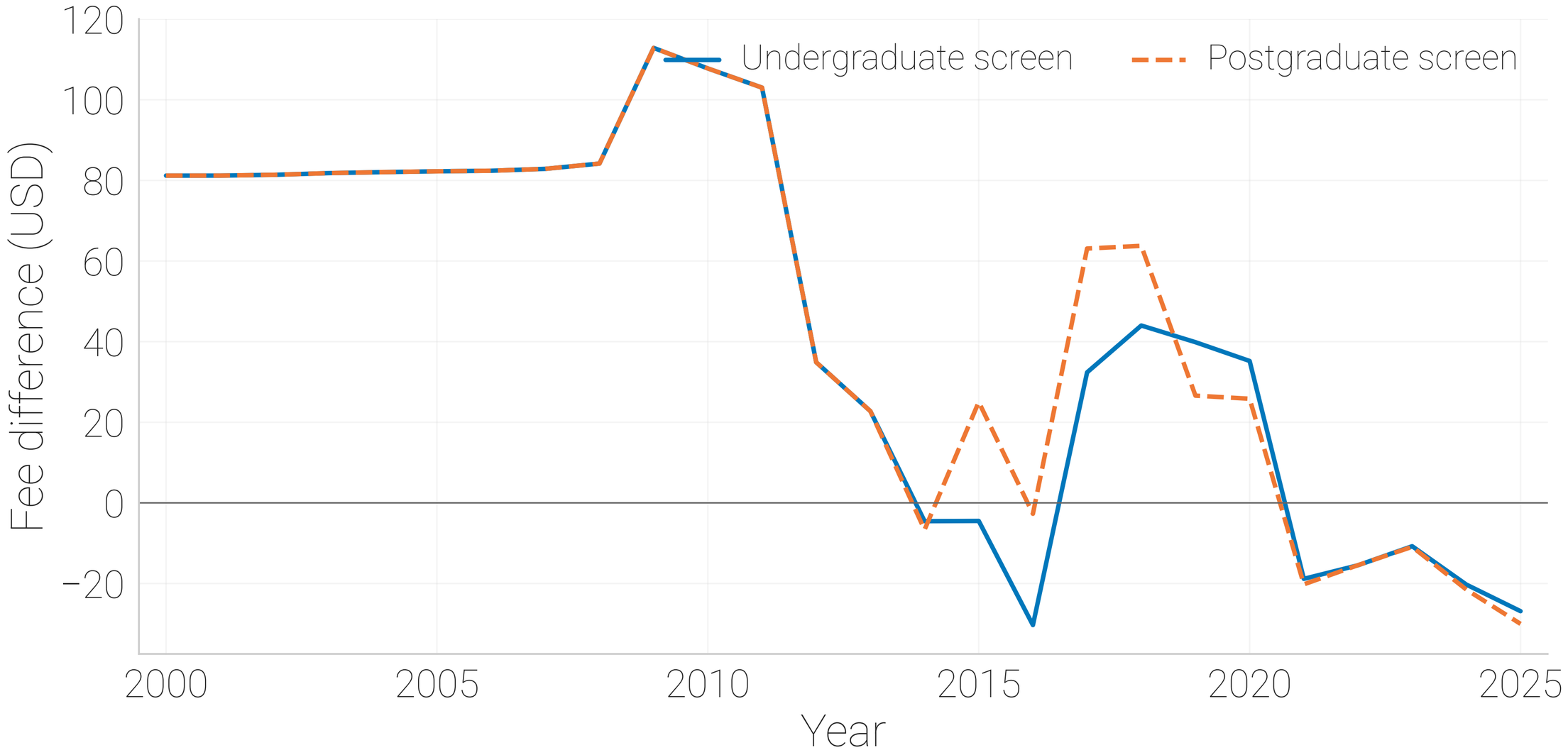
Represented route records · preserve unknown and inapplicable states



▶ Return: family-rights comparison
▶ Return: screening

Joint fee contrasts keep comparisons within a profile cell

SOC 15 · employer-sponsored minus explicit-none routes · comparable applicant fees

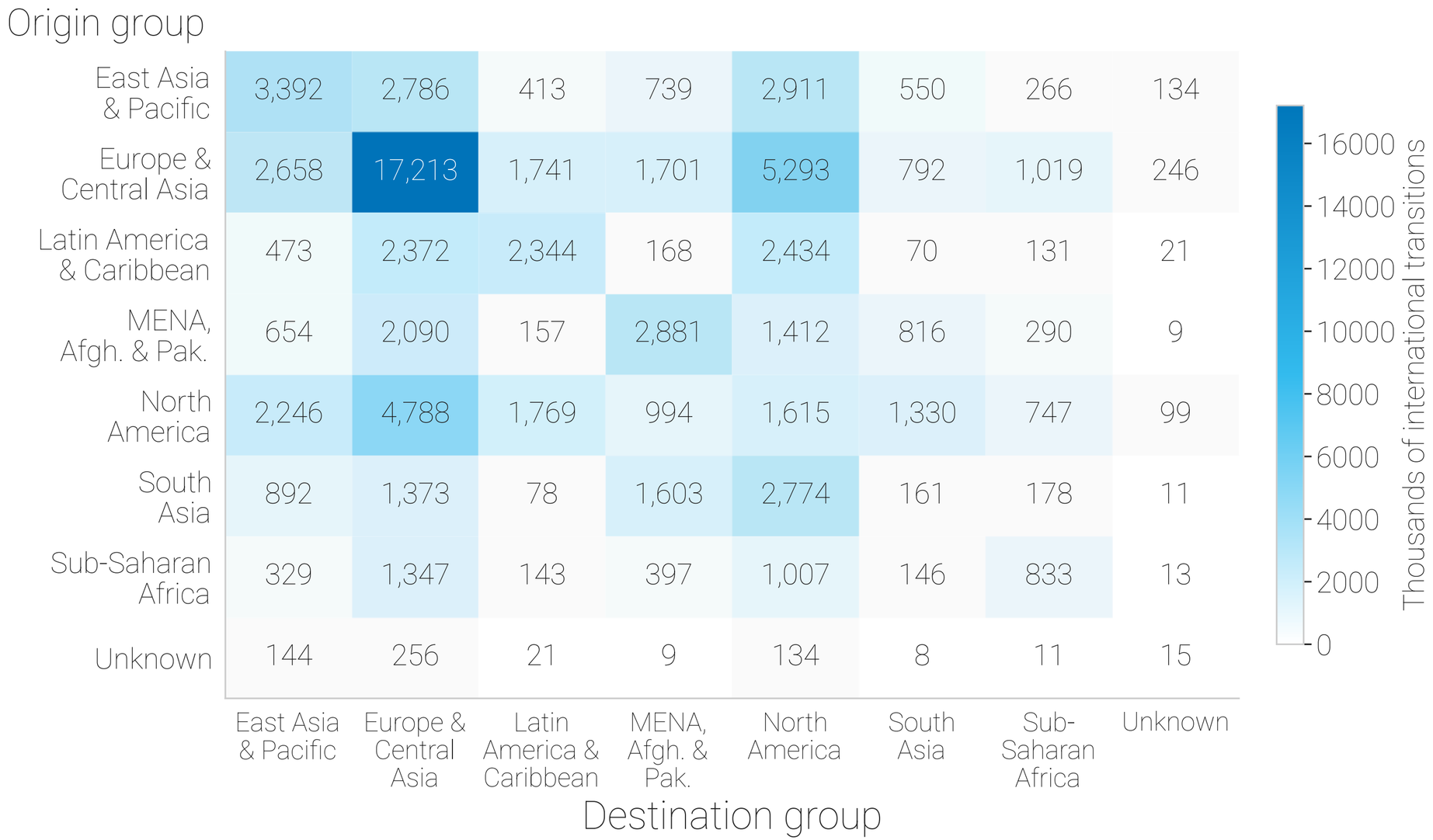


▶ Return: screening

Appendix: international mobility

Region-to-region international transition volumes

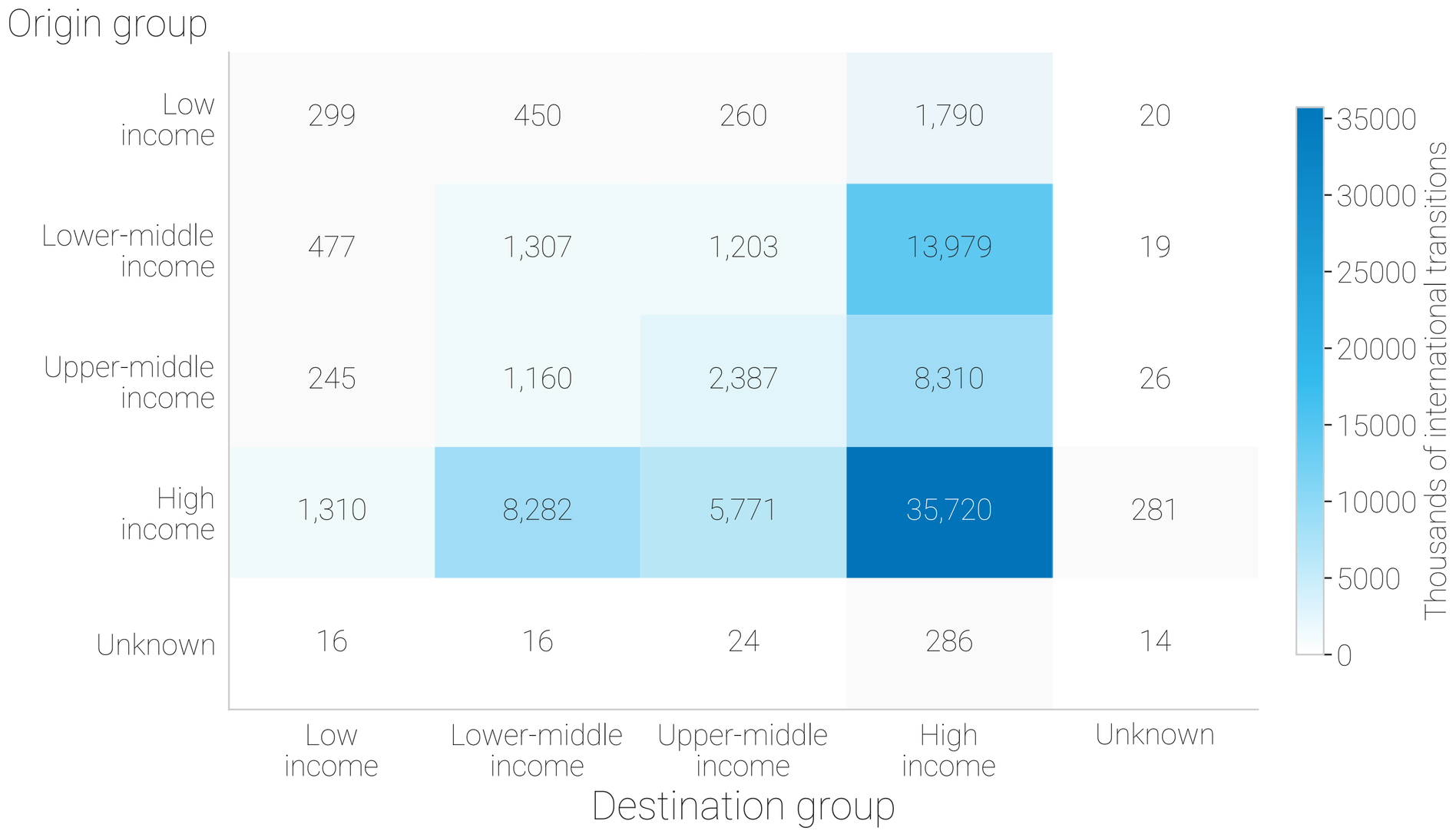
2010–2025 · fixed World Bank 2026 regions · repeated international events



▶ Return: origin-conditional shares

Income-group transition volumes reflect origin size too

2010–2025 · fixed World Bank FY2011 groups · country income, not personal wages



▶ Income shares ▶ Return: regional transitions

Origin-to-destination occupation volumes

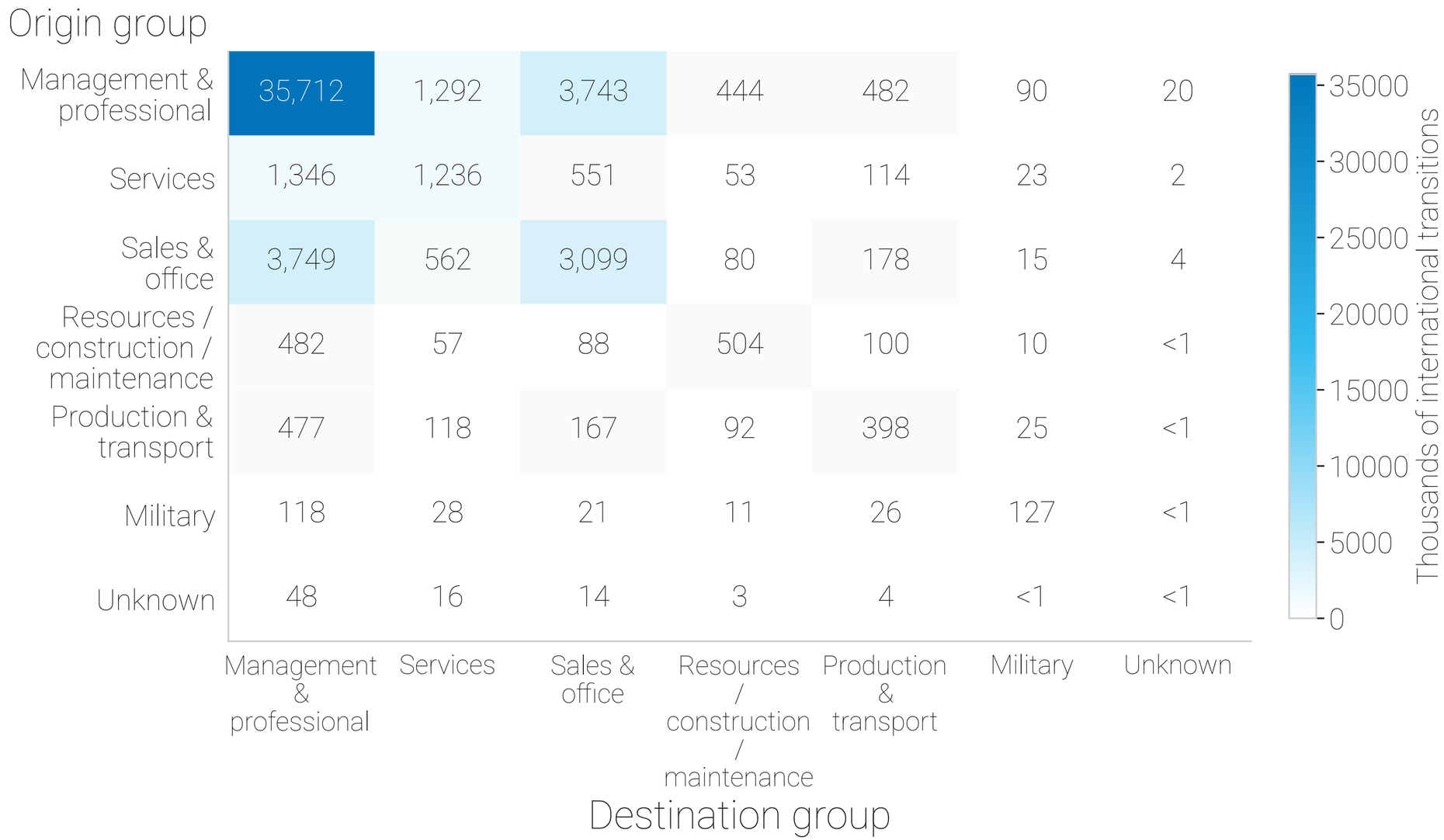
Recognised SOC major groups · international events · no ordinal skill interpretation



▶ Detailed occupation shares ▶ Return: occupational families ▶ Return: family counts

Broad occupational-family transition volumes

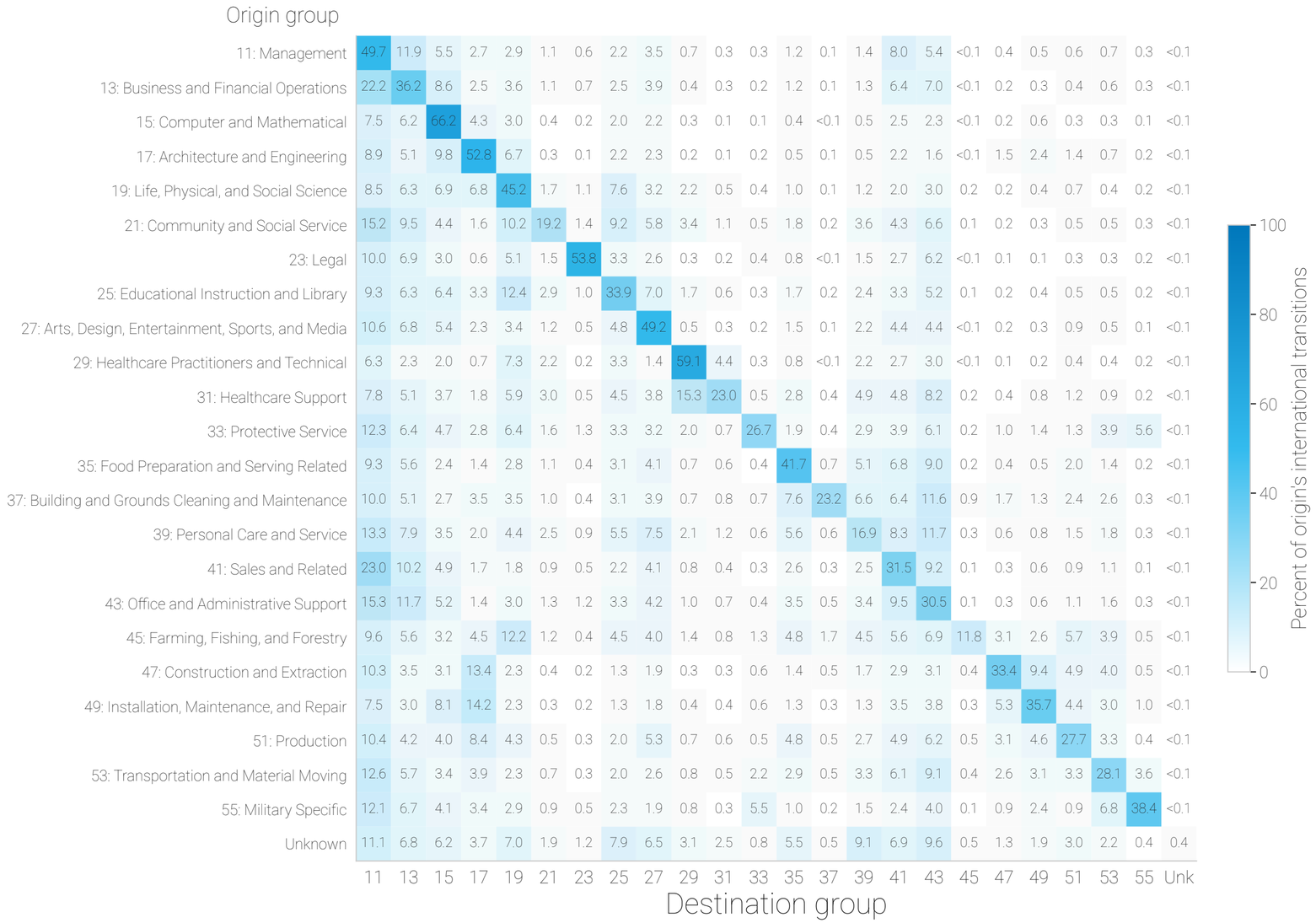
Six analytical families plus unknown · repeated international events



▶ Return: family shares ▶ Detailed SOC counts

The full matrix retains every SOC major group

23 groups plus unknown · origin-conditional shares · detail for discussion and zoom



▶ Detailed counts ▶ Return: occupational families

Occupational groups are not a skill ladder

- SOC major groups describe kinds of work; their numeric codes are not ranks.
- The broad SOC-to-ISCO reference scenario permits upward, downward and equal changes for about **95%** of events.
- Routine/non-routine, cognitive/manual and preparation requirements are distinct concepts.
- A defensible skill-transition matrix needs a verified finer code/vintage and a declared crosswalk; it cannot be recovered from destination skill marginals.

The occupation matrix is descriptive evidence. A ranked skill matrix is not yet established.

▶ Return: occupational transitions ▶ Taxonomy

Appendix: estimation and literature

Demand estimates depend on the available alternatives

Counts and shares depend on the choice set

$$\mu_{ra} = \exp(\alpha_r + \beta x_{ra} + z'_{ra}\gamma), \quad p_{ra} = \frac{\exp(\beta x_{ra} + z'_{ra}\gamma)}{\sum_{b \in A_r} \exp(\beta x_{rb} + z'_{rb}\gamma)}.$$

- Profiling the row effect gives the corresponding Poisson objective on **identical support and weights**.
- The alternatives in A_r, including staying, must be defined for the question.
- PPML can include observed count zeros; access restrictions still need a model.

▶ Return: worker responses

Fixed effects determine the monetary comparison

The variation left after conditioning determines what can be estimated

Specification	Conditional row	Additional fixed effects
L	Origin × year	Destination; occupation × education × year; dyad
D	Origin × year	Destination × year; occupation × education × year; dyad
T	Origin × occupation × education × year	Destination × year; dyad × occupation
K/E	Type-specific origins	Destination × occupation(× education) × year; dyad × occupation

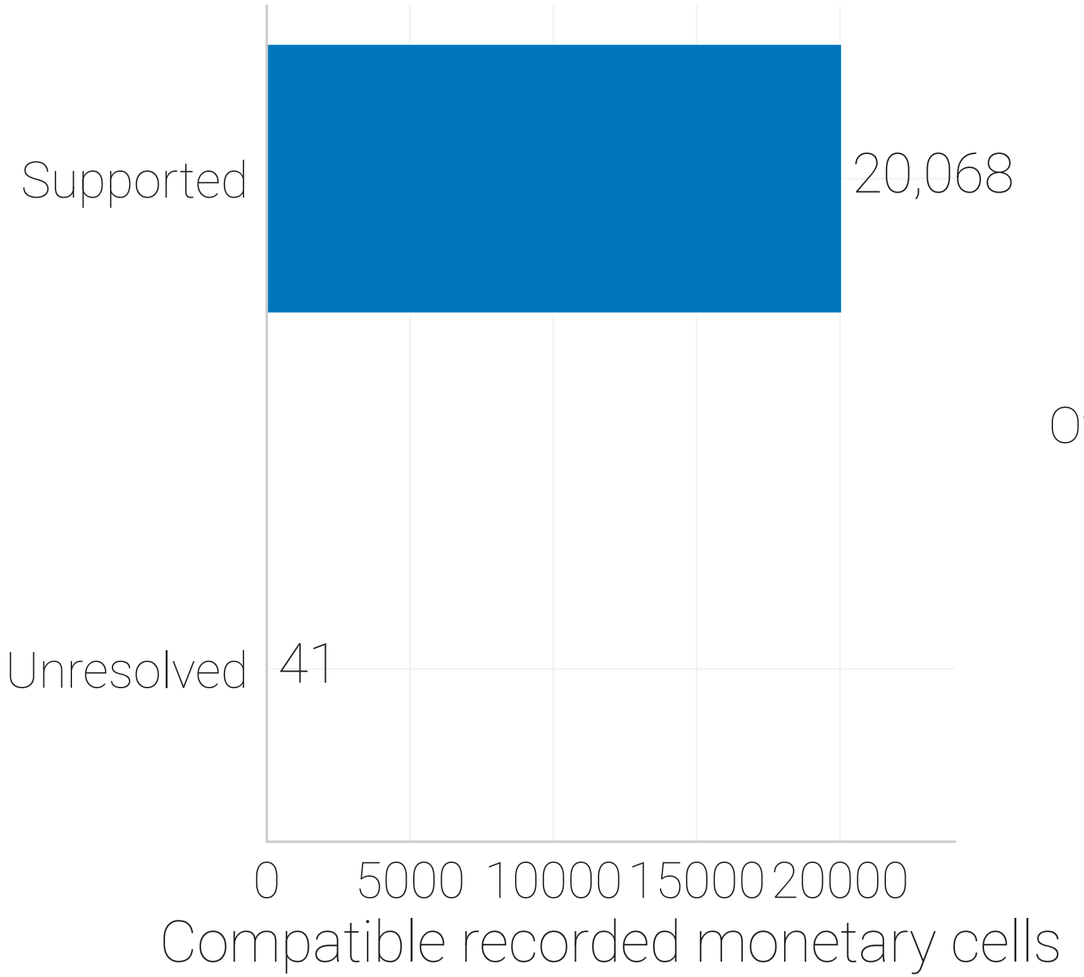
K/E absorb the monetary policy variation: **not identified**, not an estimated zero effect.

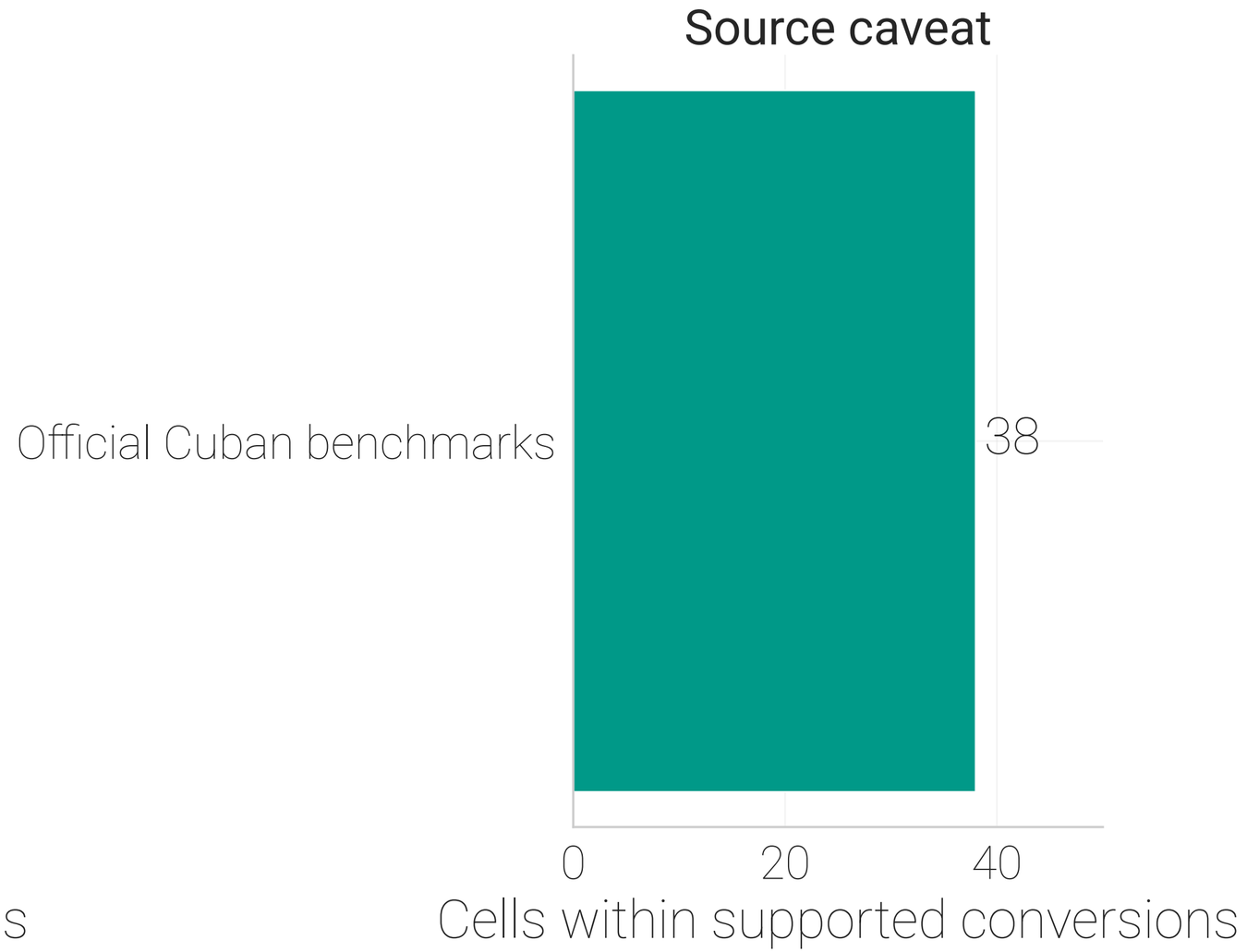
The estimand and fixed effects must leave the relevant policy variation. Dyad effects absorb fixed distance; destination-time effects absorb destination-wide offers. Neither automatically resolves individual access restrictions.

▶ Return: worker responses ▶ Return: monetary preliminaries

Monetary comparisons need compatible amounts and units

FX support is not proof of fee definition, real value or incidence





▶ Return: monetary preliminaries

Rich histories do not by themselves separate preferences from access

Observed choices combine preferences with constraints on available options

(Agarwal & Somaini, 2026; Berry & Haile, 2024)

- Legal compatibility, consideration, sponsorship, admission and take-up are distinct stages.
- Observed characteristics and repeated choices add information; they do not eliminate market-level unobservables or supply excluded variation automatically.
- Applications, refusals, route-linked admissions and usable offers can help distinguish these stages.

Our task: define the choice occasion, population, support and policy variation before treating conditional allocation slopes as migrant elasticities.

▶ Return: contribution ▶ Return: worker responses

Fee competition identifies a net marginal object

Recovering separate benefits and costs requires additional restrictions

$$G_d = f_d' n_d(f) + B_d(n_d) - C_d(n_d), \qquad c_d - b_d = f_d + (D_d^{\mathsf{T}})^{-1} n_d.$$

D_d is the own-route quantity-by-fee derivative matrix; b_d and c_d are marginal benefits and resource costs.

- Requires identified unilateral fee responses, matching fee/quantity units, interior optimality and no omitted binding constraint.
- Capacity adds a multiplier; application fees need application-stage revenue.
- Adding the same function to B_d and C_d leaves choices unchanged: unrestricted benefits and costs are **not separately identified**.

Trade-policy inversion provides a comparison, not a Visa identification theorem (Adão et al., 2025).

▶ Return: cost preliminaries ▶ Return: next steps ▶ Return: contribution ▶ Return: literature methods ▶ Return: government policy

Welfare needs a population and an adjustment mechanism

Who is affected depends on the scope of the counterfactual

- Migrants and families; origin residents; destination residents; employers; governments.
- Wages, amenities, fiscal effects and housing or other prices may adjust.
- Fees are transfers, waiting uses time, and restrictions can remove future options.
- Government recruitment gains do not establish gains for everyone affected.

Counterfactual scope: first hold other offers fixed, then allow market adjustment and government responses under explicit assumptions.

▶ Return: next steps ▶ Return: government policy

Policy measurement and allocation frame the contribution

Previous findings and the contribution to each literature

- **Policy measurement:** levels, signed changes and instrument indicators have different units (Czaika & Parsons, 2017; de Haas et al., 2018; Helbling et al., 2017).
  - → **Our contribution:** dated route bundles and comparable occupation–education profiles.
- **Alternative destinations:** multilateral resistance and third-country diversion already have direct treatments (Bertoli & Fernández-Huertas Moraga, 2013; Brinatti & Guo, 2024).
  - → **Our contribution:** connect changing legal menus to domestic and international careers.
- **Careers and equilibrium:** dynamic location choice; employer options and wage setting; connected domestic markets (Borusyak et al., 2026; Kennan & Walker, 2011; Townsend & Allan, 2025).
  - → **Our contribution:** cross-country legal-menu measurement, with government and employer responses as proposed extensions.
- **Identification and policy:** constrained demand and revealed policy objectives require setting-specific restrictions (Adão et al., 2025; Agarwal & Somaini, 2026; Berry & Haile, 2024).
  - → **Proposed extension:** identify worker substitution before recovering government incentives under explicit restrictions.

▶ Return: contribution ▶ References

Career histories have close empirical precedents

Professional trajectories, place values and policy-induced location choices

- **Return and onward careers:** professional histories trace return migration and foreign experience (Amanzadeh et al., 2024).
  - → **Our contribution:** connect those trajectories to dated legal-route measurement, not claim the first use of onward histories.
- **Place and human capital:** employment histories reveal conditional place premia and allocation patterns (Bhalothia et al., 2025).
  - → **Our contribution:** measure the legal offers and constraints facing comparable profiles.
- **Policy and founding location:** a start-up visa changes entrepreneurs' location choices (Lee & Glennon, 2023).
  - → **Our contribution:** a broader route/history mapping rather than one programme or corridor.

▶ Return: contribution ▶ Demand framework

Screening and causal gravity inform different steps

Mechanism recovery, information timing and policy-effect identification

- **Inverse screening:** allocations, transfers and outside-option restrictions can identify types and costs (Aryal & Zincenko, 2024).
  - → **Proposed use:** specify what visa choices must reveal before interpreting an inferred government cost.
- **Sequential screening:** information timing and regularity shape multidimensional menus (Gao, 2026).
  - → **Proposed use:** formalise which worker attributes and signals are known when a route is offered or chosen.
- **Causal gravity:** staggered policy effects require comparison and aggregation assumptions (Nagengast & Yotov, 2025).
  - → **Proposed use:** distinguish policy-effect identification from structural demand or government-objective recovery.

▶ Return: estimation ▶ Government incentives

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▶ Return: contribution ▶ Return: conclusion ▶ Return: literature map